PROKOFIEV'S SECOND PIANO CONCERTO: ITS GENESIS, FORM, AND NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

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By
Katarzyna Marzec
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Examining Committee Members:

Charles Abramovic, Advisory Chair, TU Keyboard Department
Joyce Lindorff, TU Keyboard Department
Michael Klein, TU Music Studies: Music Theory
Cynthia Folio, External Member, TU Music Studies: Music Theory

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ABSTRACT

This monograph fills the regrettable gap in scholarly research on Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto. By using recently published materials from the Russian archives, it clarifies the contradictory records and opinions on the concerto's genesis and history, and also identifies Prokofiev's sources of inspiration in the categories of form, style, and expressiveness. The second part of the monograph contains an analysis of the dramatic and narrative content of the Second Piano Concerto, inspired by musical hermeneutics, semiotics, and narrative theory. The analysis uncovers the means used by Prokofiev to create the unusually dramatic tone and intertextual sublayers contributing to the puzzling and often ambiguous nature of the piece. Furthermore, the analysis of the contextual and intertextual meaning reveals how performance tradition has influenced the reading of the piece's ambiguities, and how occasionally it contradicts the score's semiotic content and the composer's indications. Most importantly, it shows how Prokofiev's tendency toward irony and mockery is reflected in musical form.

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I would like to thank the Graduate School of Temple University for co-sponsoring my research at the Prokofiev Archive in London.

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For

Piotr
Nolan
The Little One Who Still Has No Name
and
Tristan

who all had to endure
waiting
for the completion of this project……

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Prokofiev remains one of the most popular composers of the twentieth century. If anything, his popularity has only grown in recent years. Western researchers have easier access to Russian archives and have discovered new pieces, or previously unknown versions of well-known masterpieces.[1] Prokofiev's music has been liberated from a tint of a politicized perspective and harsh criticism since the fall of the Iron Curtain. For decades, his life and music were interpreted and judged accordingly to the political stance of a writer or scholar. As recently as 1991, Richard Taruskin infamously declared on the pages of the *New York Times* that some Prokofiev's works from the Soviet times should not be performed at all (April 21, 25). Taruskin's radical view rivals that of the Soviet authorities from 80 years ago, when many of Prokofiev's earlier works composed in Europe were denied any value and disappeared from the Soviet stages for many decades (the list of works prohibited by the Soviet authorities included *The Scythian Suite, The Love for Three Oranges, Semyon Kotko, The Story of a Real Man*, The Second, Fourth and Fifth Piano Concertos, Third, Fourth and Sixth Symphonies [Brown 1963, 104]).

The Second Piano Concerto, composed when Prokofiev was still a conservatory student, shared such a mixed fate. This work of a 21-year old composer was from the beginning overshadowed by the flashier and more accessible First Concerto. Prokofiev himself seemed to favor the First Concerto, perhaps because it earned him the coveted Anton Rubinstein prize in piano performance from the St. Petersburg Conservatory. He

1 Recently Simon Morrison discovered an unknown, original version of *Romeo and Juliet* by Prokofiev, which premiered on July 4, 2008 at the Fisher Center for the Performing Arts at Bard College in New York state.

managed to publish it very quickly, just in time to hand in the newly printed copies to the astonished members of the examination jury at the conservatory.

The Second Piano Concerto, in contrast, was not immediately successful. Prokofiev did not publish it until 1923, ten years after its premiere, and only after a thorough revision. By that time, the Third Piano Concerto had already been successfully premiered in Paris with Sergei Koussevitsky conducting (1922), and it was well on its way to becoming Prokofiev's most popular piano concerto. The newly reconstructed Second Piano Concerto was premiered two years later, on May 8, 1924, also under the baton of Koussevitsky with the composer at the piano. Although it was favorably received, it failed to gain wider recognition. For many years Prokofiev remained its only performer. In 1923 he boasted to Albert Coates that only he was able to play it (Nice 2003, 195). Prokofiev presented the revised version several times in Russia, Europe and the United States. However, by 1934 the concerto was no longer in his repertoire. Over the next 50 years the Second Piano Concerto was performed and recorded only incidentally. The Soviet Authorities did not embrace it, which made it impossible to promote it within the USSR. It remained largely unknown abroad until the first recording by Jorge Bolet in 1953, most likely the first recording of this piece. Even then, very few pianists dared to touch this "disgracefully difficult and mercilessly tiring" concerto (Nestyev 1961, 245), as Prokofiev described it in a letter to his mentor Nikolai Tcherepnin (1873–1945). David Nice writes in a review of a recent recording by Anna Vinnitskaya:

> A decade ago I'd have bet you there were only a dozen pianists in the world who could play Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto properly. Argerich wouldn't touch it, Kissin delayed learning it, and even Prokofiev as virtuoso had got into a terrible mess trying to perform it with Ansermet and the BBC Symphony

Orchestra in the 1930s, when it had gone out of his fingers. (Nice 2011)

In the course of the last decade or two, however, this concerto has risen from the ashes. It has been performed frequently and recorded by a great number of pianists, among others Evgeny Kissin (2009), Yundi Li (2007) and Freddy Kempf (2010).[2] Many have praised it as one Prokofiev's best works, which "allows us to see much more of his heart exposed than in any of the others" (Nissman 2002). Indeed, the unusually dramatic content of this concerto prompted David Nice to add a fifth, "tragic line," to Prokofiev's famous identification of four elements in his compositional style: classical, toccata, modern, and lyrical (2003, 88).

Still, despite its growing popularity, the concerto history hides many unknowns that have not been explored in depth. It is commonly believed that the source of this atypical outburst of romantic and dramatic music can be found in the suicidal death of Prokofiev's close friend, Maximilian Schmidthof, to whom the concerto is dedicated. Despite Prokofiev's own assertions that he finished composing the concerto before Schmidthof's death, some writers continue to interpret the concerto's "agonizing form" as a result of "the shock of Schmidthof's death" (Toradze 1998). Recently published *Diaries* (Prokofiev 2002, 2006, 2008) not only submit conclusive, detailed evidence that the concerto was completely finished before Schmidthof's death, but also offer new insight into other possible sources of Prokofiev's inspiration.

There is no consensus between biographers about what happened to the original manuscript of the concerto, besides the fact that it was lost in St. Petersburg while Prokofiev was traveling abroad. The current version was reconstructed by Prokofiev in 1923 while he was staying in Ettal, Germany.

[2] The complete list of recordings appears in Appendix B.

Also, there are mixed records about the process of the revision of the concerto, ranging from assertions that Prokofiev re-wrote the piece entirely from memory, to beliefs that he consulted a solo piano score (Ledbetter 2006), or a two-piano reduction of the original version (Nice 2003). There is also no consensus pertaining to the extent of the introduced changes. Ledbetter assumes that "any changes were relatively minor," while Nice believes that the cadenza of the first movement was "composed afresh to even more gargantuan specifications."

Despite the concerto's hundred years of existence and its many intricacies, as of yet there has been no comprehensive study of the Second Piano Concerto. The available research to this point only consists of short analytical passages in biographies, CD liner notes, and program notes. The longest descriptions of the concerto can be found in the biographies of Nestyev (1961, 73–76) and Nice (2003, 93–99). Still, the nature of those paragraphs is primarily historical and anecdotal, and cannot be considered conclusive. This monograph hopes to fill the regrettable gap in scholarly research on Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto. Contradictory records and opinions on the concerto's genesis and history need to be clarified. Intricacies of the form and the extraordinarily dramatic content of the piece call for a more thorough analysis and explanation.

In the second part of this monograph, I will analyze the dramatic and narrative content of the Second Piano Concerto by using Robert Hatten's theory of markedness, topics, and musical gestures (1994). There are many elements in the form of this concerto that are marked by their uniqueness. The first performance of the concerto in Pavlovsk left "listeners frozen with fright, hair standing on end" (Karatygin's review in Nestyev 1961, 75). It is my belief that this strong reaction was dictated not only by the concerto's

modern sonorities, but also by its dramatic content. Taking into account the newest developments in the field of musical semiotics, this monograph will examine the Second Piano Concerto's narrative structure and the meaning it creates.

New and Old Sources

For many years writings about Prokofiev remained heavily polarized. Harlow Robinson was one of the first biographers to offer a more balanced view. He writes in the preface to his biography:

> It became clear to me that Prokofiev's life and music had been recounted and interpreted from two equally unsatisfying and incomplete points of view. One was the official Soviet version, propounded by generations of Soviet musicologists and writers, that insisted (at least until very recently) upon regarding Prokofiev's decision to leave Russia in 1918 as the biggest mistake of his life. The other was the "Western" version, argued with particular vehemence by members of the Russian emigration, which has insisted on the opposite: that his decision to return to the Soviet Union in 1936 was the biggest mistake of his life. (1987, x)

An example of the first view is seen in the books by Israel V. Nestyev written after the composer's death, which remain the basic source for knowledge about Prokofiev's life. Nestyev's first biography of Prokofiev was planned for the composer's fiftieth birthday but was actually published five years later, in 1946. The following edition (1961) was not only extended to include Prokofiev's final years, but also revised to meet new, politically corrected standards. Malcolm Brown wrote a telling review of Nestyev's biography, where he discusses in detail how the biographer's position changed over time. The second, “Western” view mentioned by Robinson is exemplified in Victor Seroff's *Sergei Prokofiev: A Soviet Tragedy* (1979).

Luckily, Prokofiev wrote extensively about himself, providing first-hand accounts of events and his thoughts. His correspondence, diaries, and autobiographies are

indispensable sources, which are finally being released to the public, albeit slowly. After the composer's death in 1953, many of the manuscripts, letters, and diaries were seized by the Soviet authorities and, by an act from April 26, 1955, public access to them was prohibited for a period of 50 years. After the ban expired, the Glinka Museum in Moscow published (in 2001, 2004, and 2007) a series of collections of documents from Prokofiev's Soviet period (Morrison 2008).

Another wealth of original materials and documents became available through the establishment of the Serge Prokofiev Archive at Goldsmiths College, University of London. The initiative for the existence of the archive came from Lina Prokofieva, the composer's first wife, who set up the Serge Prokofiev Foundation. After her death in 1989, the Foundation created an archive with all available materials relating to Prokofiev, including family papers. Celebrations of the fiftieth anniversary of Prokofiev's death in 2003 prompted the creation of the Serge Prokofiev Association, which started a biannual scholarly journal, *Three Oranges*, featuring many articles and materials from its holdings.

Many new publications appeared after the Russian archives opened in 2003. Two researchers are prominent in unearthing the unknown documents: Simon Morrison of Princeton University and David Nice, a London–based musicologist. Simon Morrison recently published *The People's Artist: Prokofiev's Soviet Years* (2009), a volume based on the previously unpublished sources. Another collection he edited, *Sergey Prokofiev and his World* (2008), contains previously unknown documents from the Russian State Archive of Literature and Art in Moscow and the Prokofiev Estate in Paris, as well as essays from the participants of the Bard Music Festival on previously unexplored areas of Prokofiev's life and music.

Still, the outburst of new publications focuses mostly on the works from the Soviet period. As this monograph's interest encompasses the years 1912–24, there is little in the newly published material that illuminates this particular period. Even though works from Prokofiev's early years were not subjected to harsh criticism as much as those from his years of travel in Europe and the United States, the Second Piano Concerto's revised version was included on the list of "Western" pieces condemned by the Central Committee of the Party in 1948.

The most important new source of knowledge about Prokofiev's early life has been the recently published *Diaries* of the years 1907–33 (the last volume of which still awaits translation into English). Sergei Prokofiev was a meticulous diarist from an early age. His *Diaries* offer an exceptionally detailed picture of daily activities and thoughts, providing researchers with indispensable tools in establishing the correct timeline and sources of inspiration for each composition, along with insight into his private life. Although the diaries from his childhood and the Soviet years have been known for many years, the ones from the Conservatory years were translated and published only very recently. Prokofiev's son, Svatoslav, who edited and "deciphered" his father's shorthand in preparation for the Russian edition, marvels in the forward to the *Diaries*: "It was a miracle that the diaries from the Conservatory days survived at all" (2003, xii). The composer's mother, Maria Grigorieva, preserved and brought some of them with her to France, despite the extreme hazards of the prolonged trip and the interment in the Prince's Islands off the Coast of Turkey. Prokofiev's mother held in her suitcase another treasure: the two-piano version of the Second Piano Concerto.

Other parts of the diaries were saved by Boris Asafyev and Prokofiev's other

friends, who passed them on to Sergei Koussevitsky. Eventually they were given to Nikolai Myaskovsky (1881–1950), who returned them to Prokofiev in 1927. When Prokofiev decided to come back to Russia in 1936, he did not take the diaries with him, but left them and a portion of his correspondence in a safe in the US, unbeknownst even to his family. After the archive was transferred to the USSR in 1955, and the subsequent 50-year old ban, Prokofiev's heirs decided that it was their moral right and duty to publish this priceless document as soon as the ban was lifted. Therefore, the complete Russian version, encompassing the years 1907–33, was published in 2003. The English translation by Anthony Phillips is a work in progress: the first volume (1907–1914) appeared in 2006, second (1915–1923) in 2008. The final volume (1924–1933) is promised for January 2013.

CHAPTER 2

GENESIS, COMPOSITIONAL PROCESS AND THE INITIAL RECEPTION OF THE SECOND PIANO CONCERTO

From the first sketch until the premiere of the revised version in Paris, the compositional process of the Second Piano Concerto encompassed a span of twelve years. Prokofiev began working on it while still a conservatory student and finished the reconstruction process after having composed many of his masterpieces, including the Third Piano Concerto, operas and ballets (*The Love for Three Oranges*, *The Fiery Angel*, *Chout*), and a number of solo piano pieces (Piano Sonatas No. 3–5, *Visions fugitives)*. From the beginning, the Second Piano Concerto provoked strong reactions. Its premiere in Pavlovsk turned into the biggest scandal of Prokofiev's career, with the audience booing and leaving the hall in protest. The following performances received very mixed reviews—from enthusiastic to dismissive and indifferent. For many years it virtually disappeared from concert stages, first in the aftermath of World War I, and later in the 1930s and ‘40s, when Prokofiev stopped performing the work. Its infamous difficulty scared away virtuosos of the day. Recently, however, it has been embraced by a growing number of performers. Still, academic research has not followed the renewed interest in this piece. Too many mysteries surrounding the Second Concerto remain unsolved, and many misconceptions continue to be circulated in program notes and liner notes of recordings. On the next pages I will detail the compositional process as Prokofiev himself described it in his *Diaries*, comparing this record with other existing sources of biographical information.

Genesis

Prokofiev first mentions the Second Piano Concerto in his *Diaries* on November 27, 1912 with this laconic statement: "I did some work on the Piano Concerto (No.2) and moved it forward" (2006, 242). The year 1912 brought so many events—among others, the first performances of his First Piano Concerto—that Prokofiev did not keep up with recording his activities daily or even weekly, so the diary entries are few and far between. What we do know is that Prokofiev spent the summer of 1912 working on his opera *Maddalena*, but without a performance in sight, he only orchestrated the first scene.

The summer of 1912 for Prokofiev was a time of intense practice on his First Concerto in preparation for its premiere, which took place in Moscow on July 25, 1912, with the composer as soloist, and Konstantin Saradzhev conducting. In addition to the formidable task of preparing the concerto's solo part, which "by the way is not at all easy, and I have to play it well" (Robinson 1987, 85), Prokofiev worked on several other concertos (by recommendation of his teacher, Anna Yesipova): Beethoven's *Emperor*, Rubinstein's Fourth, and Rachmaninov's First and Second. The composer proudly recounts his first major performing experience:

> I had a great success both in Moscow and in Pavlovsk, playing two or three encores each time, and I got a dozen or so press notices. Although Sabanayev wrote such a scathing review it was laughable, the others all acknowledged my talent; even though some of them were inclined to grumble, others praised me to the skies. There is no doubt that these appearances have established me as a 'real' composer with an enviable position relative to the musical hoi polloi. (Prokofiev 2006, 234)

These positive reviews encouraged Prokofiev to compose even more vigorously. He spent the second half of the summer working on the Piano Sonata, Op. 14 as well as revising and re-orchestrating his old Symphony in C minor, which he turned into the *Sinfonietta*,

Op. 5. His talent of working on several pieces at once is evident in this remark: "Once the Piano Sonata was finished, the material for the Ballade [for Cello and Piano, Op. 15] was already composed in my head and I was able to realize it quite easily" (Prokofiev 2006, 242). About the same time as he worked on the Second Piano Sonata, he composed the Toccata, Op. 11 and finished the Ten Pieces for Piano, Op. 12 (he started working on some of these pieces as early as 1906). Some ideas for the Second Concerto must have already been sprouting in his mind by the time he finished working on Op. 15 at the end of October 1912.

Compositional Process of the Original Version

The compositional process of the Second Piano Concerto is described in much detail in Prokofiev's *Diaries*. The value of these diaries is hard to overestimate.

> Prokofiev's "dnevnik" ("diary"), an edition of a pile of notebooks preserved at the Russian State Archive of Literature and Art in Moscow since 1955, is at once a sensational illumination of the composer's creative outlook and an indispensable contribution to the history of modernism. The diary is also a phenomenally entertaining read, reflecting the composer's unfailing stylishness as a writer. (Morrison 2005, 233)

After a substantial pause in recording his daily activities (from the fall of 1911 to the fall of 1912), Prokofiev resumed writing in his diaries with renewed energy and commitment. Between November 27, 1912 and May 27, 1913, he mentions different stages of work on the Second Piano Concerto on more than twenty occasions.[3] By comparison, his First Piano Concerto was described only once, retrospectively, in August 1912. Exactly six months after the first entry, Prokofiev announced triumphantly: "At four o'clock I finished the *Finale* of the Concerto. Apart from the trio of the *Scherzo*, the work is

[3] See the Timeline Table, Appendix A.

complete" (2006, 417). Interestingly, on March 20, 1913, Prokofiev declared that he was completing the trio of the *Scherzo*, which was "as charming as can be," and that he wrote the orchestral score of the whole trio ("eight pages") on April 17.

Besides providing a chronology of the compositional process, Prokofiev often offers insights on other aspects of his work, like harmony and orchestration. Even more enlightening is to know how his work on the concerto was intertwined with other activities, both musical and extra musical. Prokofiev worked on the Second Piano Concerto in two main spurts: one in December 1912, the second in March–April 1913. He was forced to interrupt work on the concerto because of conducting performances, including Tchaikovsky's opera, *The Queen of Spades*.

Perhaps the most significant finding from the *Diaries* is that, from the onset of the work on the Second Piano Concerto, Prokofiev was deeply engaged in the study of Tchaikovsky's life and music. On several occasions he mentions how reading Modest Tchaikovsky's biography of the composer touched his imagination and inspired his work: "When I got home, I read more of *The Life of P. I. Tchaikovsky*. I am entranced by this book, mainly because I find it such a tremendous spur to composition. I have begun the scherzo of the Concerto" (Prokofiev 2006, 247). Besides reading the biography, Prokofiev was learning and practicing Tchaikovsky's Second Piano Concerto: "In the morning I practiced the Tchikinson (sic) Concerto and also worked on composing my own (243). I slept late, then practiced the Tchaikovsky and also worked on the new sketches I had made for my concerto. In form and construction my Second PC is going to be a consummate piece of work" (259).

Prokofiev was exposed to Tchaikovsky's music on many occasions even before he

became a student at the St. Petersburg Conservatory. His notebook of 1904 lists all the Tchaikovsky operas he knew and played as excerpts: an early *Oprichnik*, *Vakula the Smith Cherevichki*, as well as *Eugene Onegin* and *The Queen of Spades*. While composing the Second Piano Concerto, the young Prokofiev was constantly surrounded by Tchaikovsky's music, and entranced by it. He was thrilled to be chosen by his conducting teacher Tcherepnin to conduct *The Queen of Spades*. On December 28, 2012 he went to see Tchaikovsky's *Eugene Onegin* and "was moved to tears." A few weeks later he went to hear a concert of chamber music by Tchaikovsky. Most strikingly, just a few days before the premiere of the Second Piano Concerto in Pavlovsk and after hearing Tchaikovsky's Sixth Symphony on the same stage, Prokofiev "went into ecstasies over its closing pages, their sonority and the expressivity of their mood" and proclaimed "Down with dryness in music!" (2006, 485). Prokofiev did not stop at entrusting these thoughts to his diaries. He befuddled a music critic, Karatygin, the most ardent supporter of his modern style, stating that he had become more conservative and an "aficionado of Tchaikovsky." There is no doubt that "striving for a greater depth" in the Second Piano Concerto can be at least partially attributed to young Prokofiev's infatuation with Tchaikovsky's music.

> Years later, in 1941, Prokofiev wrote in his autobiography:
>
> > It seems to me that concertos (except the very best or the very worst) can be divided roughly into two categories: in the first the solo part is well coordinated with the orchestra, but less interesting for the performer (Rimski-Korsakov's concerto), and in the second the solo part is excellent but the orchestra serves merely as accompaniment (Chopin's concertos). My First concerto was closer to the first type, my Second to the latter. (1992, 243)

In the midst of working on the Second Piano concerto, Prokofiev entrusted another thought to the pages of his *Diaries*:

> What would be the ideal way to compose a concerto? It occurred to me today that it would certainly be interesting for a pianist to be presented with a concerto that had had its origin in a technically challenging sonata and subsequently been transformed into a concerto. (2006, 280)

A few months later, in March 1913, when his work on the new concerto was almost completed, he realized that "the orchestra is given no material whatsoever to present independently, and the pianist, once having started to play, does not cease until the final bar." Consciously or not, he seemed to follow on his earlier thought of writing a concerto a la sonata, not so much in its formal structure, but in the way the thematic materials are balanced between the piano and orchestra. An entry on December 30, 1912 provides an additional insight to Prokofiev's new vision:

> When writing a concerto, if you conceive of it as a combination of piano and orchestra, the pianistic side of the solo part will always suffer. This has happened in about half the passages in my Concerto No. 1 where the piano-orchestra combination is effective but not particularly interesting for the pianist to play. When composing the Second Concerto I paid a great deal of attention to the challenges of the solo part, but even so there are times when the composer-musician in me prevails over the composer-pianist, and I have not been able to avoid dull or, so to say routine, passages for the soloist. (2006, 280)

Perhaps the "composer-pianist" eventually prevailed in the revised version, as it is impossible to find dull or routine passages in the current piano part.

The technical advancement of the piano part can be traced to Prokofiev's dramatically improved piano technique. The list of piano compositions he learned in a relatively short period of time is truly impressive, especially since he was simultaneously composing, conducting, and rehearsing a great number of pieces. Certainly working on Tchaikovsky's Second Piano Concerto under Yesipova's demanding supervision seasoned him technically. Other pieces that Prokofiev worked on while composing the Second Piano Concerto were three formidable sonatas: Liszt's B minor, Chopin's B-flat minor,

and Grieg's E minor. That winter he also played concertos by Saint-Saëns and Grieg. In March 1913 he started working on Schumann's Sonata in F-sharp minor and Beethoven's Sonata in C minor, Op. 111. Certainly such an advanced virtuosic menu explored in a relatively short period of time solidified his own technical prowess and spurred his imagination, pushing him to create new limits of piano technique. On April 9, 1912 Prokofiev proudly described the effects of his work: "Played through on the piano the first movement of the Concerto and was enraptured by the splendid sound of the cadenza, the first time I had been able to play it right through" (2006, 365).

Prokofiev's legendary ability to compose several pieces at the same time is evident in the compositional process of the Second Piano Concerto. He worked concurrently on all the movements of the concerto, first establishing the plan, then filling in the details, figurations, and at the very end providing an orchestration. This passage about the last movement provides valuable insight:

> . . .a particularly successful passage has finally begun to flow in the development. The main thing is that up to now I have not been able to get the form of the second half of the *Finale* completely clear in my mind: this has been causing me a great deal of trouble and inhibited all desire to compose. But today the form manifested itself with great clarity down to its details. True, it does not conform to the best of old traditions, but in itself it is entirely logical and complete, and that is all that matters. I have great respect for the old forms, but I also have complete faith in my own instincts, and often give myself license to depart from convention. (Prokofiev 2006, 346)

Prokofiev could not help comparing himself to his beloved composer, Tchaikovsky. He noticed that he did not work as swiftly as the old master, and immediately found an explanation:

> . . .as a composer it must be admitted that I work slowly—nowhere near the rapidity of Tchaikovsky, who could turn out an entire opera scene in two days or thereabouts. One explanation of this could be Tchaikovsky's relative indifference to the harmonic aspect of his music: it takes much less time to write a melody

> than it does its harmonic accouterments. But I am always absorbed in the latter, with the result that after three hours or so productive and uninterrupted work there can still be less than a page to show for it. (2006, 317–318)

Even though Prokofiev composed at the piano[4], his compositional process was cerebral first, and pianistic second. He described how he could not shorten the *Intermezzo*, even though it turned out to be too long, as any changes would destroy the formal structure he envisioned.

Orchestration

By no means was Prokofiev a novice in regard to orchestration. He wrote his First Symphony as an 11-year old boy under the guidance of Reinhold Gliere. During his conservatory years he completed several orchestral scores and had three of them premiered: *Autumnal*, Op. 8, *Dreams*, Op. 6 and the First Piano Concerto. A particularly interesting work is his *Sinfonietta*, Op. 5/48, which is the first piece he composed in a light, neoclassical style. It is hard to understand why this delightful piece is not performed more often—Prokofiev himself was puzzled by this fact. Like the Second Piano Concerto, the *Sinfonietta* was re-written, and it is impossible to know the extent of the changes he made in the revision. Prokofiev maintained that in the three revisions he made, in 1911, 1914–15 and 1929, he was merely polishing the orchestration. David Nice points out that "the work's most impressive characteristic, the transparency which is offset by occasional flourishes of a more acerbic style, belongs to the world of the European years" (2003, 66). Still, it is clear from Prokofiev's *Diaries* that he consciously designed light, transparent textures in this piece, inspired by the *Sinfonietta* of Rimski-Korsakov:

[4] In later years Prokofiev forced himself to compose away from the piano; according to his *Diaries*, he composed the Classical Symphony while walking.

> At present I'm in Sontsovka writing a *Sinfonietta*. This is how the idea of the piece came into being. Scriabin's *Extase* was being played at a Belyayev concert, and at the rehearsal it was being dismembered section by section (…). When they got to the end I assumed there would be a complete run-through from the beginning, but instead… suddenly they launched into Rimski-Korsakov's *Sinfonietta.* It was such an unexpected contrast that Myaskovsky and I could not help looking at one another and bursting out laughing. After Scriabin's elaborately majestic music with its colossal layers of complexity, its maelstrom of confusing tempi, its gripping climaxes culminating in ecstatic outbursts, Korsakov's *Sinfonietta* appeared so small, so self-effacing, but at the same time transparent as water and so lovely! It was a delightful little scrap of a child side by side with a monstrous giant. It came to me with blinding clarity that both kinds of music could be good, and could be enjoyed; both compositional genres were valid. And gradually I arrived at the conclusion that what I should do during the summer was compose both a large-scale work and a little *Sinfonietta.* (2006, 99)

The "little *Sinfonietta*" turned into a five-movement work, but still under 20 minutes long. As he planned, Prokofiev started composing the *Sinfonietta* in the summer of 1909, but since the work became more substantial, he did not finish until Christmas of that year. The year 1910 brought his two symphonic poems, *Autumnal* and *Dreams*, written in a style Prokofiev described as "misty and reflective" (2006, 212). If *Sinfonietta* was inspired by Rimski-Korsakov, the two symphonic poems show a direct lineage to Scriabin's symbolic and mystical style (*Dreams* is also dedicated to Scriabin). *Dreams* was premiered at the Conservatory on November 22, 1910, with Prokofiev conducting. "I was happy, proud and busy as can be. I shall appear in the Great Hall in all my capacities simultaneously, as composer, conductor and pianist" (2006, 189). Prokofiev also performed his Second Piano Sonata at the same concert. He heard *Dreams* twice more the following year, in Moscow and Pavlovsk. Certainly hearing his own orchestral compositions made him proud, but also let him test and refine his orchestrating skills. The lessons he learned were applied to the First Piano Concerto, which he completed in February of 1912:

> While composing the Concerto I took pains to ensure that the piano would at all times be heard and would always be pleasing to the ear when combined with the orchestra. In this I was successful, but there are places where from a purely pianistic perspective the piano part is not particularly interesting. Nevertheless to the listener it sounds effective and impressive". (Prokofiev 2006, 237)

Prokofiev started orchestrating the score of the Second Piano Concerto on April 1, 1913:

> In the evening I pressed on with orchestrating the Concerto. Previously I had wanted to delay making a start on this until all the music, in particular the solo piano part, had been composed in detail. Now, however, with only a few short passages remaining to be written out, I decided not to wait any longer, but to start on the instrumentation, intending to complete the unfinished passages in between whiles. I started writing the score with immense satisfaction. While going through the composition process I had already been working out in my imagination the orchestral texture I wanted, so there was no difficulty in laying out on the pages of a full score the light and transparent accompaniment I envisaged, nor the notation of the solo piano part. A very enjoyable process. (2006, 359)

In the Second Piano Concerto Prokofiev took pride in making the orchestration very light. "I am proud of the fact that the orchestral texture of the Concerto is so transparent. I had difficulties with one passage where the brass section of the orchestra drowns the soloist...but strange as it may seem, I particularly like this place" (361). He must be referring here to the entrance of the orchestra after the cadenza of the first movement. Prokofiev was well known to write scores quickly and economically. He noted on April 1: "the score turns out to be shorter (fewer pages) than I imagined, the orchestral accompaniment being of such transparency that each page can accommodate more than one line of full score" (2006, 361). Another one of his inventions was writing the parts of all the transposing instruments in the key of C. This sped up the process of writing the full score and made it certainly easier to conduct or read; eventually, however, the copyist had to transpose these parts back to the traditional transpositions when writing out the individual parts.

Despite well thought-out techniques, Prokofiev worked on orchestration longer

than he first envisioned. On March 20 he optimistically predicted: “I do not expect orchestration to take very long: I want to keep accompaniment simple and transparent.” A month later, on April 19 he wrote: “In the morning and until two o'clock orchestrated the *Intermezzo*. Thank God, the end is in sight, and tomorrow I should finish it. But my God, what a long piece it has turned out to be!” Four days later: “I really had not expected the orchestration to drag on for so long.” And again, on April 25: “I am beginning to wonder anxiously when I shall ever finish the Concerto: the *Finale* is pretty long, and there is the two-piano version to do, and all this with the Graduation Concert coming up for which there is going to be a mass of work.”

Prokofiev did not delay the two–piano version until the orchestral score was completed. While working on the orchestration, he was changing to the piano reduction when his “brain refused any longer to conjure up orchestral combinations” (2006, 360). The reduction was not completed until March 7, 1914. Eventually the manuscript was ready to be sent to the publisher, Russian Music Editions, on April 13, 1914. Unfortunately, the eruption of political unrest, and eventually the First World War, rendered all his publishing plans fruitless. On September 15, 1914, Prokofiev wrote in despair: “I have no one to send my Second Concerto to!” (2006, 736) as his last-chance publisher, Boris Petrovich Jurgenson was called up to the army as a former officer, despite his grey hair and older age. The Second Piano Concerto remained unpublished until 1925[5].

[5] Malcolm Brown mistakenly wrote in the review of Nestyev’s biography, that the two-piano version was published by Gutheil in 1914 (Brown, 1963). Prokofiev’s *Diaries* rebut this theory.

Premiere and First Reviews

The premiere of the Second Piano Concerto in Pavlovsk was described as a scandal rivaling that of Stravinsky's *Rite of Spring* in Paris (which had happened barely three months before), establishing the work's ultra-modern reputation. Hearing the piece now, one wonders if the first version was so much different from the version we hear today. In 1913, reviewers on both sides emphasized the novelty of the concerto: its unassuming beginning, dissonances, and colossal cadenza. Prokofiev proudly copied the reviews into his diaries—especially those that enhanced his image of an *enfant terrible*. However, as Harlow Robinson rightly brings to our attention, the audience of the summer concerts in Pavlovsk was not necessarily equivalent to that in Paris.

> The Russian general musical public of 1913 was conservative and unadventurous—considerably more conservative than the European public at that time… Petersburg's cultural climate was even more conservative than Moscow's, and the Pavlovsk's concerts (unlike the Evenings of Contemporary Music where the audience expected to hear something shocking and new) drew a particularly cautious public that wanted to enjoy unchallenging music in a pretty setting as they sipped champagne—rather like the summer music audiences at Tanglewood or Saratoga Springs. (1987, 97)

Even before the premiere in Pavlovsk, Prokofiev presented the Second Concerto to many of his friends, asking for their opinion. His friend Myaskovsky liked this Concerto even more than the first one: "It's very fresh and interesting, and in a more intimate vein than the First, but also more difficult. He (Prokofiev) played some of it for me—there are wonderful bits, quite novel and most intriguing" (quoted in Nestyev 1961, 73). Even though Myaskovsky's style differed significantly from Prokofiev's, as he preferred dense textures and dark scoring he excitedly praised this "classical concerto composed with lucidity of form, concision of thought and a definition and prominence of outline" (quoted in Nice 2003, 94). Whereas the press reviews concentrated on the scandalous

aspects of the concerto and its "barbaric" features, Myaskovsky, being a composer himself, appreciated more the beauty of the *Finale*'s second theme than the striking dissonances of the infamous *Cadenza colossale.*

After the legendary premiere on August 23, 1913, the press was abuzz. According to Nestyev, there were twelve reviews in different newspapers, eight of which were decisively negative. However, most of them were written by non-musicians and published in the "gutter press" of St. Petersburg (Nestyev 1961, 76). Nestyev, with delight, quotes the spiciest of them: "a Babel of insane sounds heaped one upon another without rhyme or reason" (Y. Kurdyumov in *Petersbursky Listok*), "a cacophony of sounds that has nothing in common with civilized music….Prokofiev cadenzas, for example, are unbearable. They are such a musical mess that one might think they were created by capriciously emptying an inkwell on the paper" (N.Berstein in *Petersburskaya Gazeta*).

In the biographical books on Prokofiev, two reviews have been quoted most often: the first signed by an anonymous, self-described Non-Critic, and the second by Prokofiev's friend and an influential critic, Viacheslav Karatygin (1875–1925). Karatygin's was the only decisively positive review in the group. The Non-Critic focused his review on the reaction of the audience and appearance of the young Prokofiev:

> On the platform appears a youth with the face of a Peterschule student. It is Sergey Prokofiev. He seats himself at the piano and begins to strike the keyboard with a dry, sharp touch. He seems to be either dusting or testing the keys. The audience is bewildered. Some are indigent. One couple stands up and runs toward the exit. "Such music is enough to drive you crazy! What is he doing, making fun of us?" More listeners follow the first couple from various parts of the hall. Prokofiev plays the second movement of his Concerto. Again the rhythmical collection of sounds. The most daring members of the audience hiss. Here and there seats become empty. Finally the young artist ends his Concerto with a mercilessly discordant combination of brasses. The audience is scandalized. The

> majority hiss. Prokofiev bows defiantly and plays an encore. The audience rushes away. On all sides there are exclamations: "To the devil with all this futuristic music! We came here to enjoy ourselves. The cats at home can make music like this!" (Nestyev 1961, 76)

Upon reading this review, Prokofiev recollected: "The Petersburg Gazette had an amusingly written article, which I liked very much" (2006, 491). His *Diaries* also offer a detailed account of the premiere:

> I hurried on to the stage, my entrance being greeted with applause. I was quite calm at the beginning of the Concerto, but in the middle of the cadenza began to lose my nerve, and went wrong in the *colossalo*. In fact it sounded fine, but the truth is I was improvising whole passages rather than playing exactly what I had written. There was some applause at the end of the first movement, so I got up and bowed. Aslanov, as I had requested, made a long pause between the first and second movements, smoothed down his hair, wiped his nose, and eventually under cover of his handkerchief smiled at me and asked if it was all right to continue. I inclined my head. The *Scherzo* began at quite a slow tempo and was easy to play, and following Myaskovsky's advice I played the whole thing *pianississimo*. In the trio I again became nervous and made mistakes, but after running up and down some chromatic scales instead of my written passages I quickly got back on track, so that nobody noticed my blunder. I was extremely worried in the Intermezzo that I might modulate to a tonality I did not mean to, and indeed this did happen, resulting in a highly disagreeable moment when I heard the orchestra coming in in a different key to the one I had landed on. Nevertheless I quickly managed to extricate myself, and in the *Finale* I was quite calm and it went better.
>
> Following the violent concluding chord there was silence in the hall for a few moments. Then, boos and catcalls were answered with loud applause, thumping of sticks and calls for "encore." I came out twice to acknowledge the reception, hearing cries of approval and boos coming from the hall. I was pleased that the Concerto provoked such strong feelings in the audience. (Prokofiev 2006, 488)

Karatygin's review praised the "extreme, hyper aesthetic' sensitivity of the harmonic nerves of the artistic organism." He dismissed the negative reaction of the public: "The public hissed. This means nothing. Ten years from now it will atone for last night's catcalls by applauding unanimously a new composer with a European reputation" (Nestyev 1961, 77). Even though the general public needed at least ten years to embrace Prokofiev's music, the next performances received much warmer reviews from the

musical press. But, since the main concert organizations in Russia—those run by Siloti and Koussevitsky—remained hostile or indifferent to Prokofiev's music, he relied on promoting his Concerto through a circle of friends.

Prokofiev describes a musical gathering that took place on September 3, 1913 in Karatygin's house. The invited guests included many composers and musicians: Nicolai Tcherepnin, Yevgeny Braudo (1882–1939), Mikhail Gnessin (1883-1957) and many others. They gathered to listen again to Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto. "The Concerto was met with tumultuous acclamation, people described it as the most interesting event of recent times. I am considered to be a modern classic." (Prokofiev 2006, 498).

Prokofiev also presented his newly composed concerto to Alexander Glazunov (1865–1936), the director of the Saint Petersburg Conservatory. Glazunov admitted that the Second Concerto was a significant development over the First. But, upon hearing Prokofiev play the *Intermezzo*, even though he admired the pianist and liked "the very individual and interesting piano style," he did not understand the music itself. "Very interesting. Splendidly done. But the music…very strange…especially the middle section" (Prokofiev 2006, 418). Glazunov never warmed up to Prokofiev's music, and he was so unhappy with the jury that granted the Rubinstein Prize for Prokofiev's performance of his First Piano Concerto, that he initially refused to announce the verdict.

Alexander Siloti (1863–1945), another important figure on the Russian musical scene, was hostile to Prokofiev's creative output at the time. A pianist himself, he was a pupil of Rubinstein, Liszt, and Tchaikovsky, and the teacher of Rachmaninov. Like Prokofiev, he also was a winner of the Gold medal (at the Conservatory), and was one of

the most important and celebrated Russian musicians, hosting a prestigious concert series. Siloti's crude remarks about the "stench" of Prokofiev's music as compared to the "aroma" of French composers, provoked a fiery rebuttal from Myaskovsky, published in the pages of *Muzyka*: "[Siloti] only recently gracefully dodged an opportunity to include in his programs Prokofiev's wonderful Second Piano Concerto (which, as is known, has one quality that no one disputes—powerful individuality) with a vague promise to consider the composer when he has 'found himself.' Glory to the sensitive ear and keen insight of Mr. Siloti!" (Nestyev 1961, 84).

The year 1914 brought a life-changing event—Prokofiev won the Rubinstein First Prize for the performance of his own First Piano Concerto. He became a celebrity, and for the first time his music obtained a stamp of approval from the Conservatory professors. The multiple articles about his music by Karatygin and Myaskovsky, as well as pressure from other supporters of Prokofiev (Tcherepnin, Ossovsky), eventually resulted in invitations for performances from both Koussevitsky and Siloti.

In January of 1915 Prokofiev performed the Second Concerto again, this time for the Russian Musical Society, a prestigious and conservative musical institution. To present his work in the best light and avoid the pitfalls exposed during the premiere, he started practicing the piano part well in advance (in 1913 he had started memorizing the piano part barely a month before the concert). His *Diaries* record daily practice sessions from early October 1914: "It is a good time to start learning the Second Piano Concerto so as to avoid a great rush at the last moment" (2006, 748). His diligent preparation paid off, as he reported to his friend Myaskovsky on January 25, 1915:

> Yesterday I performed my Second Concerto at RMO with great success, although some individuals couldn't restrain themselves and used it as a chance to hiss at

> me. Malko conducted fairly well, and I conscientiously learnt my part by heart. So whoever was disappointed in music found consolation in the pianist. Auer, Artsybushev, Fitelberg, Siloti all rather unexpectedly turned out to be of favorable opinion concerning the concerto. (Robinson 1998, 243)

Another friend, Asafyev, shared his delight at his friend's success:

> If only you had been here to see how pleasant it was. Prokofiev plays with a triumphant air at the R.M.S.?! And his lovable smiling phiz (sic) gazes indifferently at the giggles, hisses, etc. Splendid! (Nestyev 1961, 98)

Right after this successful performance Prokofiev went to Italy, at the invitation of Sergei Diaghilev. The dangerous trip through Romania and Bulgaria on the brink of a war declaration and through the battle zone proved worth his efforts. Even though Diaghilev did not approve of Prokofiev's *Ala and Lolli* (Prokofiev reused material from this ballet in his *Scythian Suite*), he commissioned a new ballet. This time he asked again for Russian music, criticizing heavily Prokofiev's score: "What on earth are you, a Russian composer with a Russian theme, thinking of, writing international music?! This will not do" (Prokofiev 2008, 22). Diaghilev was so convincing in his arguments, that Prokofiev, without much fight, "agreed to eliminate half the music from the ballet...And completely revise the subject" (23).

Diaghilev also organized a performance of the Second Piano Concerto in Rome, with the prestigious Augusteo Orchestra (now St. Cecilia) under the baton of Bernardino Molinari. The concerto was presented on February 18, 1915 to an audience of two thousand. Prokofiev describes the event in his *Diaries*:

> At first I was not nervous at all, but there were places in the middle where I was. I did not tire in the Scherzo, but in the *Finale* I became so dreadfully exhausted I could scarcely carry on to the end. All in all it was not bad, but I did not play as well as I had done in Petrograd, and Molinari's accompaniment was less accomplished than it had been in the rehearsal. After the first movement there was applause, more restrained clapping after the third movement and at the end of the piece I was received quite warmly. The solo

> pieces I played in the second half of the concert were better liked than the Concerto. (2008, 22)

Indeed, the reviews of the performance were not very complimentary. According to Nestyev (1961, 99), "almost an entire press (*Tribuna*, *Concordia*, *Giornale d'Italia*, and others), after paying due respect to the young Russian's virtuosity, severely criticized the Second Piano Concerto ('nightmarish,' 'tricks,' 'meaningless piano exercises')." The following review must have left a particularly bitter aftertaste: "We had expected to find a new Stravinsky, tart and interesting, but on the contrary we found an artist still lacking individuality and wandering between the old and new" (99). Prokofiev played his concerto just two weeks after Stravinsky's great success in the same venue. Incidentally, the two composers had adjoining rooms in the hotel, and they became friends: "we unlocked the communicating door and had long conversations in the mornings and evenings. When he heard my Second Piano Concerto, *Toccata* and the Second Sonata, Stravinsky was seized by the wildest enthusiasm, declaring that I was a real Russian composer, the only one to be found in Russia" (Prokofiev 2008, 29). Stravinsky also offered a suggestion about the first movement of the Second Concerto, which Prokofiev incorporated in the consequent performance but eventually eliminated—the cadenza was to be divided into two halves by giving an interjection to the horns.

Prokofiev gave a total of seven performances of the first version of the Second Piano Concerto. After his return from Italy, he played it four more times: with Hugo Wahrlich and the Court Orchestra (April 13, 1915); with Nikolai Malko in Sestraretsk (June 27, 1915), once more in Pavlovsk (June 14, 1916), and in Kiev (November 18, 1916).

The events of the Russian Revolution of 1917 and the fact that Prokofiev had

composed a great number of new pieces that he needed to promote (*Scythian Suite*, the "Classical" Symphony, the Violin Concerto, the cantata *Seven, They Are Seven* and many others) suspended further performance plans for the Second Piano Concerto. By 1917 Prokofiev had also composed a substantial part of his Third Piano Concerto. Even though the last reviews in Russia were much more laudatory then the first ones, the Second Piano Concerto remained much less accessible than his other pieces, such as the First Piano Concerto, or the "Classical" Symphony. It is not a coincidence that the first reviews were negative both in Russia and Italy, although for different reasons: in Russia it was considered too modern, in Italy not modern enough. The Second Piano Concerto does need several hearings to understand its complexity and appreciate its wealth of ideas.

Legend of Schmidthof and Personal Circumstances During the Time of Composition

Certain legends are so deeply ingrained in the collective memory that years of rebuttal by respected sources do not eradicate them. Prokofiev himself on many occasions explained that he finished the process of composing the Second Piano Concerto before the sudden and unexpected news of his friend's suicidal death. He dedicated this Concerto to Schmidthof's memory, but that does not imply that he composed it with his friend's death in mind. At one point Prokofiev wanted to dedicate all subsequent works to the memory of his dear friend. All of Prokofiev's respected biographers—Nestyev, Robinson and Nice—agree with this record. Still, as recently as 2001, the New York Times critic, Allan Kozinn, wrote: "In the case of this concerto, we know the program: Prokofiev wrote the work after learning that a close friend had committed suicide, and its

textures are dark, passionate and, not least, angry." In Kozinn's defense, he was writing this article on Toradze's performance of the Second Piano Concerto (with the Kirov Orchestra and Gergiev conducting), and was apparently convinced by the pianist's unorthodox and historically false "program" attached in liner notes to his recording of the Second Concerto (Toradze 1998). Still, neither the pianist nor the critic followed the rules of proper scholarship and failed to check their facts before publication. Here is Mr. Toradze's version:

> In our view the Second Piano Concerto stands out as Prokofiev's most personal statement. The circumstantial background of this music is vitally important. Prokofiev dedicated the Second Piano Concerto, along with other works from the same period, to the pianist Maximilian Shmitgoff (*sic*). In April 1913 Prokofiev received a letter from his friend, who had gone on vacation to the Gulf of Finland: "Dear Serioja, informing you of the later news—I just shot myself…" Prokofiev was undone by this tragic event. Although he had already sketched some ideas for a future concerto, and shared them with Maximilian, it was the shock of Shmitgoff's death which shaped this piece in its agonizing form. (Toradze 1998)

The persistent legend circulates widely in most concert program notes and on the Internet. Even if a writer does not go as far as to indicate Schmidthof's death as a direct inspiration to the concerto, it is implied in the tone and structure of the review. Here is Barbara Nissman, a respected pianist and writer on Prokofiev:

> Dedicated to the memory of his dear friend, Max Schmidthof, whose suicide at a very young age deeply affected the young Prokofiev, the haunting melody of the opening theme conveys feelings of loss and nostalgia, a yearning for what might have been. The emotional extremes contained in this movement range from childlike innocence to the depths of despair—rage verging toward craziness. (Nissman 2002, para.1)

There is no doubt that Max's death was a tremendous shock to Prokofiev. Even though Schmidthof used to talk about suicide from a philosophical perspective, Prokofiev never expected him to end his life. In fact, he was spending much time with Max in the days

leading to the suicide, attending concerts, going on walks, and pursuing girls with the usual sense of humor and mischief. On April 25, Max listened to Prokofiev's *Rigaudon* and *Allemande* from Ten Pieces for Piano, Op.12, and friends talked about Prokofiev's idea of selling the Op. 12 to Jurgenson for 1000 roubles. They also planned some extravagant purchases for an upcoming trip: a Spanish hat and a very natty pair of shoes. On April 26, the friends didn't meet, as Max was already on his way to Finland, unbeknownst to Prokofiev. Max did not go on vacation to Finland; he secretly went there with one purpose—to commit suicide far from St. Petersburg, saving his mother and friend the embarrassment of press releases. Prokofiev searched for his friend for several days, until someone found a note in a Finnish newspaper about Max's body being discovered in a forest near Vyborg.

As the timeline in Appendix A shows, by the time of Schmidthof's death the Second Concerto was almost finished, a far cry from "some ideas" being "sketched." Prokofiev even played the concerto for Max as he was making progress in the composition process. In the days following Max's death, however, Prokofiev did not compose at all, but tried to fill the lonely days playing the piano. When he resumed composing (on May 4), he finished *Rigaudon*, the piece he played for Max a day before his disappearance. Even though in the days preceding Max's death Prokofiev frantically composed the Second Piano Concerto for many hours each day, he did not touch it again until May 13, and when he did, he was only working on a piano reduction. Finally, May 16 brought a change of mood: "In the best of spirits. Worked on orchestrating the *Finale*." The first composition fully conceived and finished after Max's death was another *Rigaudon*, this time in a quick tempo and a lively, jolly style. The one conceived

before Max's death turned out not to be an actual *rigaudon*, as it was too slow.

The *Diaries* show with great detail that Prokofiev had an uncanny ability to compose profound and deeply expressive themes concurrently with leading the happy life of a mischievous prankster, and, in reverse, to compose lively, humorous pieces at times of sadness and despair. As a twenty-one year old student, his thoughts were appropriately fixed on a number of "romantic interests," which he juggles in his *Diaries* not by names but numeric symbols. Both Prokofiev and Schmidthof spent many joyful hours designing pranks, anonymous postcards, drawings, caricatures and little humorous poems to various objects of their attention. Nice suggests that Prokofiev had a romantic relationship with Max, but even reading in between the lines does not support this claim. Nice substantiates his theory with very vague statements by Lina Prokofieva, the composer's wife (who never met Max) about the chess club to which Prokofiev belonged, as promoting "multi-tastes, you know, different tastes" (Nice 2003, 59). Simon Morrison also raises questions about the credibility of Lina's statement:

> Evidence for the claim comes from letters and diaries penned in florid late-nineteenth century style, and from an interview between Prokofiev's widow Lina and Harvey Sachs. Lina's vague confirmation of the relationship may be flawed; it was made late in her traumatic life, which included incarceration in Soviet labor camps, when her memory was weakening. (Morrison 2003, 521)

Certainly the culture in Russia permitted very close, warm and loving relationships between men, where ending a friendly letter with "I kiss you on the lips" was a common occurrence.

Valery Gergiev, who has recently become the most visible promoter of Prokofiev's works, said, "much of Prokofiev's music is programmatic rather than abstract, in the sense that his works are highly emotional responses to his milieu" (Kozinn, 2001). In

many of Prokofiev's works this is true—one immediately thinks about his "War" piano sonatas. However, the time during which he composed the Second Piano Concerto—fall 1912 into spring 1913—was hardly traumatic. Prokofiev was so busy with his composing, conducting, practicing piano, and pursuit of his lady friends that he missed any signs of Max's despair. The letter he received on April 27 struck him "like a blow to the head: 'I must give you the latest news—I have shot myself.'" Prokofiev describes his first reaction, written down a few days afterwards: "I thrashed about in and out of bed, rushed round the room, went over to the mirror, ran into the next room. My first semi-conscious thought was why, why, cut the cord of a life so joyously taking shape?!" (Prokofiev 2006, 382). In the course of the next days, Prokofiev realized that "every single thing my friend had told me about himself, that I had believed implicitly, had been false" (387). Max was an illegitimate child and had no claim to nobility, or even his name. "The reasons are not important," Max wrote in his letter. In fact, the reasons were too trivial to reveal to his friend—Max could no longer pretend about his status, and he could not afford a long trip to Crimea that the friends had been planning for months. At first, the "bitterness of deception" overshadowed Prokofiev's pain. He also blamed himself, as he understood that their friendship "contributed to his (Max's) ruination" (383). But Prokofiev many times displayed a remarkable skill of self-preservation. He did not allow himself to despair; instead, he surrounded himself with friends and musical activities. On the next day, April 28, he spent the evening with Myaskovsky and played him the not quite finished Concerto: "It was not easy to play it without any preparation, and at some places in the *Finale* I simply had to stop and rest my hands. Myaskovsky liked the concerto and Kryzhanovsky, who was also there, went into ecstasies over the

Intermezzo. I shall dedicate the Concerto to Max's memory" (387). Prokofiev gave a deeply personal account of his feelings much later, five months after Schmidthof's death:

> He was a rare, a nonpareil friend! It was a gauge of our friendship that I never encountered any side of Max that was antipathetic to me; his qualities were those craved by my soul, he answered all my emotional needs and as a person he was closer to me than anyone else in the world. He is no more, and I am overcome by grief. But this grief must be fought and vanquished, as must thought of Max himself. The past cannot be brought back, so what purpose is served by harking back to it? (Prokofiev 2006, 500)

Prokofiev displayed this common-sense attitude on many occasions. He never let himself brood and despair, even when facing the horrors of war or revolution. The new depths of expression he achieved in the Second Piano Concerto were not influenced by a "milieu" but by his musical imagination and need to explore more profound musical topics, inspired by the musical tradition of the 19th century.

CHAPTER 3

LOSS OF THE ORIGINAL SCORE AND THE REVISION PROCESS

Circumstances Surrounding the Loss of the Orchestral Score

The years leading to Prokofiev's departure from Russia were turbulent and full of uncertainty. From the onset of the First World War through the October Revolution of 1917 the lives of Prokofiev, his family, and friends were endangered on many occasions. His closest friend, Myaskovsky, was drafted to the Soviet Army as a former officer and eventually sent to the front. Prokofiev did not know about his friend's fate for many months. He himself was not drafted thanks to many interventions by his influential friends to the new officials in St. Petersburg. Prokofiev presented unbelievable composure and optimism in the face of the world-transforming events. "War with Germany is now certain. There are two ways of looking at it: the conventional point of view is that it is such an appalling catastrophe that one's hair stands on end with horror of it, but from the historical perspective it is terribly interesting!" (Prokofiev 2006, 717). Looking at the unfolding events from a historical perspective proved challenging when the war threatened to enclose on St. Petersburg in the summer of 1914 and Prokofiev, with his mother, decided to evacuate. They stopped in Moscow to deposit a strongbox containing all financial documents and stocks as well as Prokofiev's manuscripts, fearing that St. Petersburg was strategically too vulnerable to defend in case of war. Leaving St. Petersburg was not an easy task, as already there was a huge exodus from Western Russia. Most trains were reserved for the purpose of moving millions of soldiers to the

front lines, leaving very few to be used by civilian passengers.

Prokofiev spent most of these dangerous times either in Kislovodsk, in Caucasus, or in a little estate near St. Petersburg, where he composed in peace and quiet. The years following the premiere of the Second Piano Concerto firmly established Prokofiev as the foremost Russian composer of the young generation. Prokofiev composed a number of masterpieces during the four years of the First World War: the "Classical" Symphony, the First Violin Concerto, *Scythian Suite*, the *Gambler* (an opera), two piano sonatas*, Vision fugitives* and *Sarcasms*. His works were published and premiered despite the great turmoil of domestic war and revolution. Even though many aspects of everyday life failed to function (post and train service, food production etc.), the musical institutions of St. Petersburg and Moscow tried to thrive. One of the reasons for Prokofiev's decision to come back to Russia in 1927 may stem from his memory of this politically turbulent and unsafe time being extremely prolific and successful to him as a composer.

The end of 1917, however, encroached on Prokofiev's sense of safety. In August 1917, upon hearing that the Germans were in nearby Riga, Prokofiev packed his manuscripts, diaries and letters into a trunk, giving them to Sergei Koussevitsky, who promised to keep them in the vaults of the Russian Music Editions in Moscow. Prokofiev did not see or know about the whereabouts of this trunk for the next ten years. Eventually he received it back in 1927, after he returned to the Soviet Union.

There were several manuscripts that Prokofiev did not put in Koussevitsky's trunk. The Violin concerto was to be performed in November of 1917 and the "Classical" Symphony he left with the copyist. The Second Piano Concerto was also left in the apartment. The most likely reason for this is that Prokofiev expected to perform the

concerto soon and wanted to have the orchestral score handy. In 1922 he also mentioned that he had planned to re-orchestrate and revise the score, perhaps after his return from Kislovodsk, where he was forced to spend a prolonged summer vacation. The November performances were postponed until December due to the unrest of the October Revolution. Prokofiev was not able to travel to Moscow for a solo recital in November either, as "the Bolsheviks were gaining the ascendancy everywhere, and Moscow was under siege with crossfire from guns and rifles" (Prokofiev 2008, 238). Later he found out that a Moscow apartment was shelled on the very evening he was to spend the night there. Even in face of these calamities Prokofiev describes his state of mind very honestly:

> A strange serenity. Somehow I looked on it all as something inevitable, through which I must struggle and suffer and survive, and there seemed to be no single person whose fate would cause me grief. … How prudent had been my idea of settling in Kislovodsk! Here I stayed in spiritual equilibrium between the sun, the air, the Fourth Sonata—which I finished—Kant—which I also finished in November—Asya, walks, and games of chess with old Prince Urusov. (2008, 240)

Once Prokofiev made the decision to leave Russia for America at the end of 1917, he seemed to be very excited at the prospect of travelling to the country of "brimming" and "cultivated" life in contrast to the ""slaughter and barbaric rhetoric" in Russia and "shabby concerts in Kislovodsk" (241).

January 1918 brought more threatening news about Bolshevik victories and mob vandalism spreading over Russia. In March, Prokofiev left Kislovodsk with the intention of leaving Russia. In Moscow he witnessed a general feeling of depression stemming from the anarchy. Initially Prokofiev did not plan to go back to Petrograd[6]—apparently he

[6] The name of the Russian capital was changed from the Germanic-sounding Sankt Petersburg to the Russian equivalent, Petrograd, at the outbreak of the First World War, in August 1914.

believed that his apartment was left in a safe condition. However, as he could not secure an American visa and passport in a timely manner, he decided to visit his friends. He arrived in Petrograd on March 17 to find out that his apartment was in good shape and protected from a mandatory requisition by an entrusted family who lived there. Prokofiev's friends organized two concerts for him, and he premiered his Third and Fourth Sonatas, as well as *Suggestions Diabolique* at the beginning of April. Before he left, Prokofiev ensured that his friend Pyotr Suvchinsky (1892–1985), founder and editor of the *Musical Contemporary* journal, sent in a "dependable man," his own building superintendent, to protect his apartment. As he explained later: "I'm not concerned about my goods and chattels, and don't even mind much about my prize piano. But there were letters from several previous years in the drawer of the desk, and a thick notebook containing my diary—one of the later years, I don't remember which. I should be sad to lose that notebook" (Prokofiev 2008, 430). Surprisingly, Prokofiev does not mention the score of the Second Piano Concerto as one of the prized possessions left in his apartment. Probably he was reassured that the apartment was left under good care, and that he could count on his friends to protect it in case of any unforeseen troubles.

Prokofiev first heard rumors that the apartment was broken into and robbed in August 1920, when he received a letter from Adelina Jung, a friend of Vera Miller who was also Prokofiev's close friend and translator of his operas. In November 1920 a letter from Vera Miller confirmed the bad news:

> I got a letter from Miller in Petrograd (!), the first such a communication I had had from that city for 3 years. I was so happy to have this letter…. She confirmed that the apartment had been broken into and robbed and the papers destroyed, except for those I had given to Asafyev before I left. (Prokofiev 2008, 547)

Prokofiev did not remember giving Asafyev any papers. But he remembered that he left

the Second Piano Concerto in the apartment: "This is very bad news indeed, it means that the score of the Second Piano Concerto is lost" (Prokofiev 2008, 536). However, he added: "thank heavens Mama brought the piano score with her" (536). Having learned the news from Jung, Prokofiev tried to contact Boris Asafyev, one of the friends who was supposed to take care of the apartment, but apparently he did not hear back from him. In November he wrote to Asafyev again:

> Are the manuscripts I left in my apartment on Pervaya Rota still in one piece? According to some people I know, including Eleonora Damskaya, the apartment was left empty and deserted, and the people who moved in apparently used the manuscripts as fuel with which to fry eggs. Accordingly to others (Lourie, Souvchinsky), you got to the apartment in time and carried them off in an official manner to be preserved. Which of the two stories should I believe? (Robinson 1998, 90)

Eventually, through a number of letters circulating slowly between Petrograd and New York over the course of the next two years, Prokofiev learned the full story, and gave expression to his outrage in a long letter to Eleanora Damskaya on January 7, 1923:

> Of course there are many to blame for the destruction of my manuscripts: the Bolshevik decree allowing irresponsible individuals to be settled in apartments; and Souvchinsky with his thief of a business manager; and that scoundrel Lourie; and most of all, me, for having placed too much faith in my friends. And you know I cannot help faulting Asafiev—only a ditherer like him would be satisfied to accept Lourie's refusal. If Lourie behaved like a bastard, he wasn't the only one to turn to: there were Benois, and Gorky, and Lunacharsky. For God's sake, they managed to save Siloti's library! And you could have roused your collective diplomatic brains, if you saw that my other friends were sweetly falling by the wayside! ...You ask, am I planning to come to Russia? No*, merci,* for the moment I am not rushing to visit countries which are using my compositions for heating fuel. (Robinson 1998, 47)

There was still one tiny beacon of hope that Prokofiev tried to hold on to. He heard from Vera Miller that in the spring of 1920 the "very simple people from the countryside" who lived in the apartment "had loaded up all the contents of the apartment on carts and transported it away to their village" (Robinson 1998, 48). Prokofiev asked Eleonora to

find out who these people were, but it seems that he never found out.

Eleanora Damskaya managed to salvage Prokofiev's piano, which he received as prize with the Rubinstein Medal, but the outraged composer stated that although he was grateful for saving the instrument, "a single page of manuscript is dearer to me than three pianos" (Robinson 1998, 48). Still, in his *Diaries* from the same time, Prokofiev admits that it was not the manuscripts that he mourned the most, but his diaries and the "Sacred Yellow Book" which he wrote together with Max. The lost score of the Second Piano Concerto "does not matter greatly, because Mama brought the piano score with her from Kislovodsk, in addition to which I wanted in any case to revise and re-orchestrate it, the only problem being that this will now take much longer" (Prokofiev 2008, 691). His next note in the *Diaries* is even more telling: "All the music of the Second Piano Concerto still exists" (692). Prokofiev started revising and re-orchestrating his Second Piano Concerto soon after, and by September 1923 he was already revising the *Finale*.

Revision Process of the Second Piano Concerto

Unfortunately, the whereabouts of the two-piano reduction, which survived the unrest of the Russian Revolution and was safely transferred by Prokofiev's mother to Paris, cannot be established. It could not be found at the Prokofiev Archive at Goldsmiths College in London, which holds most of the private and family documents from the years of Prokofiev's life in Europe. Simon Morrison, head of the Prokofiev Estate and Foundation asserts that Prokofiev's family itself does not have it either. The problem of this missing score preoccupied Noelle Mann, Morrison's predecessor with the Foundation for many years. Thanks to Prof. Morrison's generous help, I established that neither of

the official collections of Prokofiev documents and scores in Russia hold the original two-piano version.

Facing the absence of the original version, the extent of Prokofiev's introduced changes remain a matter of speculation. By year 1923, Prokofiev's *Diaries* became fragmentary and less detailed in the description of his compositional activities. Some information can be obtained from published reviews of the premiere and the following performances in the United States and Russia. Some rare insights on the revision process, often contradictory, can be found in Prokofiev's letters to his friends. In July of 1924 Prokofiev wrote to Myaskovsky:

> It's hard for me to describe precisely the essence of the revisions of the Second Piano Concerto. The thematic material has remained entirely intact, the contrapuntal fabric has been made slightly more complex, the form became more graceful, less square, and then I worked to improve both piano and the orchestral parts. (Robinson 1998, 255)

A few weeks later he added somewhat enigmatically "it came out very flowery, just like the Third—perfect for children—enough then! I am going to shift to three-part polyphony!" (Robinson 1998, 258). The "flowery" aspect may indicate denser, polyphonic textures, a staple of Prokofiev's style in the 1920s. This experimental phase was later harshly criticized by the Soviet regime.

The year 1923 marks an important dividing point in Prokofiev's creativity. Up to that time he drew his musical inspiration mainly from the Russian tradition, even if only to contradict or ridicule it. The Third Piano Concerto, *The Love for Three Oranges*, *The Fiery Angel*—all these pieces were composed in direct continuation of his Russian period. According to Nestyev, Prokofiev's actual foreign period started in 1923 with composition of the Fifth Piano Sonata. From Prokofiev's perspective, he was looking for

new methods of composing, a topic which occupied him intensely. He gave evidence to his new thoughts in advice he sent to his friend Myaskovsky upon finishing his new Sonata, in a letter dating from January of 1924:

> For now, compose not thinking about music (you always write good music, that's not the problem), but instead concentrate on creating new methods, and a new technique, new orchestration; rack your brains in this new direction, sharpen your inventiveness, no matter what it takes, strive for a good, fresh sound; renounce the Petersburg and Moscow schools as you would a morose devil—and you will immediately feel not only the earth beneath your feet but even the wings on your back, and mainly—a goal straight ahead. (Robinson 1998, 250)

The Fifth Sonata's original version demonstrates high chromaticism and angularity. Prokofiev's new style is also evident in his Second Symphony, composed with a substantial effort right after the revision of the Second Concerto. This work is so complex that even the composer admitted that he did not understand it upon hearing it: "I had complicated the piece to such an extent that as I listened, even I couldn't always find the essence" (Robinson 1998, 258). Still, even if Prokofiev added contrapuntal density to the score of the Second Piano Concerto, he did not obliterate the transparency of the orchestral texture. With the exception of the climactic points, the orchestra plays a subordinate role and quite often is hidden under the denser piano part. The thematic material in all movements is presented by the piano. Prokofiev's assertion that the thematic material has not been altered (quoted above in a letter to Myaskovsky), leads to a conclusion that revisions had to take place in the developmental and contrapuntal sections. It is safe to assume that the contrapuntal writing found in the first theme group in the first movement is a product of revision, as well as similar passages in the cadenza (Figures 3.1–3.2). The young Prokofiev preferred clear, transparent textures, as seen in his compositions of the years 1912–13 (Ten Piano Pieces, Op. 12, Piano Sonata No. 2, or

the first Piano Concerto). Even the Third Piano Concerto shows more transparency and very few polyphonic textures, which is not surprising considering the fact that Prokofiev began thinking about the Third Piano Concerto as he was composing the Second. Most of the compositional process of the Third Piano Concerto happened during years 1917–22. Both concertos show similar textures and pianistic techniques. What sets them apart is a thoroughly different use of the orchestra in creation of the formal construction. One of the essential structural premises of the Second Concerto was the dominant role of the piano, and subordinate one of the orchestra. The orchestra presents none of the themes in the course of the concerto, and the piano is absent only in few transitional and extremely short sections. These experimental principles proved to be problematic in resolving the fundamental and essential characteristic of concerto form, the conflict between soloist and orchestra. Even the most laudatory critics, Karatygin and Asafyev, who wrote their extended reviews after a thorough study of the score, came to the conclusion that such limited orchestration is a liability in a concerto form. One may assume that Prokofiev introduced significant revisions into the orchestration. In one of his statements we hear that he recomposed the concerto to such a degree that it could be named his fourth (Nestyev 1961, 202). Prokofiev also complained to Myaskovsky that despite all the revisions he did not succeed in "fully developing the orchestral accompaniment" (Robinson 1998, 253), which he blamed for cool reception of the piece during its premiere in Paris. The basic formal construction remained untouched and, as a result, the skimpy orchestration (with the exception of a few moments in the climaxes) still seems to inadequately balance the extravagancies of the piano part.



Figure 3.1. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto in G minor, Op. 16. *Andantino*. The first theme group (all excerpts of Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto in this monograph come from: Boosey&Hawkes 1925, 1972. B&H 17779)



Figure 3.2. *Andantino*. Cadenza (R. 20)

Nevertheless, the structural inadequacy of the orchestration in the current version may not be equivalent to the orchestrating insufficiencies in the original score. Karatygin critique of "monotony of tempos (movements and rhythms)" seems well deserved, but his description of "dully sounding orchestra" does not stand the scrutiny of the current

version. Asafyev's review of 1915 offers insights on other weaknesses of the score that Prokofiev might have fixed in the revised version:

> *Intermezzo*—the weakest of all [movements] and leaves little impression: one hears too many obtrusive dissonances and the thematic content is pale and tiring. *Finale*, despite its rhapsodic and disjointed structure, is charming. There are many brilliant passages and splashes of inexhaustible fantasy of the composer. And there is this beautiful theme in a minor mode—too bad it was barely used! The most vulnerable side of the concerto is a weak, poorly thought-out and realized instrumentation (especially in the *Intermezzo* with its sliding and sharp sounds of basses and cellos) and some disregard for orchestral accompaniment which, instead of consistently being in agreement with the melody, jumps out of its slavish submission to an omnipotent czar-like piano, and does not wave its parallel line in support of the concertizing instrument. (Shlifstein 1956, 154)

Prokofiev gained a lot of orchestrating experience in the years following the premiere of the Second Piano Concerto. His masterful score of the Third Piano Concerto, as well as several orchestral and operatic works, give solid evidence to his skill in orchestration. Undoubtedly, he used these skills when reworking the Second Concerto, but presently we cannot know the awkwardness of the original orchestration. Some incoherence in the accompaniment and melody mentioned by Asafyev may be explained by the ironic troping of incongruous topics, which is described in detail in the analytical section of this monograph. The most telling evidence of Prokofiev's revision comes from Asafyev's remarks about the scarcity of the second theme in the *Finale*. In the revised version the second theme saturates the entire orchestral part of the *Finale*'s development section. Apparently a magnificent coexistence of the two themes was not conceived at the birth of the concerto, but is a result of a thoughtful revision. It is also possible that the original version employed some elements of the second theme in the development, but due to insufficient orchestration they were less apparent (still, Asafyev based his review on a study of the score, and several hearings of the piece; he could not have possibly missed a

simultaneous coexistence of the two themes).

Asafyev's contempt for the *Intermezzo* might have prompted more thorough revisions. Although the *Intermezzo* remains the most problematic of all the movements due to its grotesque nature and contradictory performing traditions, one would not describe it is as "pale and tiring." Certainly its arresting orchestration at the beginning and the end leaves quite a strong impression, which must be credited to the revision process.

After the publication of the *Diaries*, some writers became aware of the existence of a Trio section in the *Scherzo* and assumed that Prokofiev eliminated the Trio in 1923 (Jaffe, 2008). However, a close analysis of the movement, as well as comparison of Prokofiev's very detailed remarks about the length of manuscript result in a conclusion that the *Scherzo* as we know it, in fact, does contain a Trio section, whose length is identical with the version of 1913. Since its premiere the *Scherzo* appeared to be the most successful of all movements, and it is likely that Prokofiev did not revise this movement much at all.

David Nice believes that Prokofiev revised the concerto to "even more gargantuan proportions," including transforming the cadenza "to be the mightiest in the concerto repertoire." Two facts testify against this assertion. First, Prokofiev's virtuosic technique blossomed during his conservatory years. His Fourth Sonata, composed in 1917, shows kinship with many elements of the techniques and textures used in the cadenza: dense textures, saturated chordal structures, wide arpeggio-like runs, polyphonic layering of several lines. Back then Prokofiev still had his Second Piano Concerto under his fingers, having performed it as recently as in June of 1916. The piano pieces composed later show

simplification of textures and do not try to reincarnate the massive soundscape of the cadenza. The Fifth Piano Sonata, composed right before the revision of the Second Piano Concerto, despite its chromaticism and more complex language, is much less virtuosic. Even the Third Piano Concerto, as brilliant as it is, is less demanding and more conservative in pianistic requirements. Prokofiev explained in a letter to Myaskovsky that the slower tempos and more relaxed character of the Fifth Sonata were results of his poor health and prolonged recovery from scarlet fever. Prokofiev was also relieved when the premiere was postponed, as—due to his health condition—he was not able to practice enough. From the pianistic perspective, it is hard to imagine that Prokofiev conceived new "athletic" and "gargantuan" breakthroughs in the pianistic technique seen in the cadenza of the concerto while protecting a "heart in poor condition" (Nice 2003, 194).

First Performances and Reviews of the New Version

The composer premiered the revised concerto with Sergei Koussevitzky as a conductor on May 8, 1924 in Paris. The reviews were positive, especially when praising the pianist's virtuosity "with which few interpreters can measure up against" (*Le Gaulois*, December 5, 1924). Koussevitzky programmed Prokofiev's ten-year old concerto together with a premiere of Honegger's *Pacific 231* and Tansman's *Legende*, giving credence to its perceived modernity, even if somewhat pale in comparison with the ultra-modernity of *Pacific 231*. Prokofiev reports in the *Diaries* that he played quite well, only got tired in the cadenza of the first movement. The *Scherzo* was most successful, but in the *Finale* the orchestra got lost. The public applauded each movement and made Prokofiev bow once or twice. However, the applause after the entire concerto was

relatively small, because of the extraordinary length of the entire first part, which tired the audience (Prokofiev 2002, 256). In any case, the success of the concerto, even though considerable, could not compare to the furor of Honegger's work. Prokofiev himself was so overtaken with a strong impression of this piece that he reports thinking about it for several days after the concert, and then composing the Second Symphony under its partial influence.

A review of the revised version of the Second Piano Concerto written for *La Revue Musicale* by noted music critic Boris de Schloezer agrees in many points with Karatygin's review of 1913.

> In spite of the undeniable qualities of this music, its verve and originality, this work, in whole, produces an impression of complexity, length, sameness and, at certain times, of boredom. This is first of all… for the lack of contrast between the various parts (I had already noted a similar fault in the Fifth Sonata of the same author): very rare lyrical episodes at the beginning and in the *Finale* are surrounded by somewhat brutal, often grotesque, games. Such "footballish", athletic quality is typical of Prokofiev, whose music is certainly very amusing and agitated, but in the long run generated certain monotony. (Schloezer 1924)

It is highly ironic that charges of "footballish" quality, which—according to Prokofiev's *Autobiography* written in 1941—inspired greater the depth of the Second Concerto, are attributed in Schloezer's review to this very Concerto. Most likely Prokofiev misremembered the provenance of the quote, which since became iconic and regularly quoted in the literature about the Second Concerto.

In the next years Prokofiev performed the Second Piano Concerto with some frequency, but failed to establish it firmly in the concert repertoire. The Third Piano Concerto immediately became both the public's and critics' favorite. However, the Second Piano Concerto, despite revisions, fared rather poorly. Boris de Schloezer who told Prokofiev that he preferred the Second to the Third Concerto, writing in *La Revue*

Musicale, reversed his opinion:

> I also believe that the concern of the virtuosity that has pushed Prokofiev to accumulate the technical difficulties, especially in the *Finale*, has rendered his pianistic writing too thick, too dense. In this report, the Second Concerto appears to me well inferior to the Third, which, despite a few [weak] spots, is certainly a genius work, one of the best of the Russian School. (June 1, 1924)

Prokofiev performed the Second Concerto on his tour in the United States in 1930. The reviewer in New York, Olin Downes, while praising the work's virtuosity and the great success of Prokofiev's program (including also *Scythian Suite*), found many "purely formal ideas" (as distinguished from programmatic *Suite*) "monotonous and undistinguished" (*New York Times*, February 8, 1930). He also criticized "overworked figuration," "monotonous variation," "banality and not very much musical fertility and intensity." *The Daily Boston Globe* reviewer was more laudatory:

> The orchestral accompaniment, like the solo part, is intricate in texture, full of the acrid harmonies and strident rhythms characteristic of Prokofiev, yet one felt that music had been first conceived in a far simpler and more conventional idiom and form. Its elaboration seemed *a tour de force*…the piece makes great demands on the skill of the soloist. Nobody can crack at Prokofiev's expense the old joke that "he plays like a composer." On the contrary, he plays like a pianist of very unusual ability. Were it not for his other works, one would think from this concerto that he was only interested in writing showpieces for piano to astonish audiences by his muscular energy and agility. (February 1, 1930)

Somewhat surprising is this reviewer's claim that "there are no slow sweet melodies, no grand, sonorous climaxes. Nothing, in short, at all after the style of Liszt or Rubinstein."

In the *Chicago Daily Tribune*, Edward Moore started his review with a blunt statement—"the concerto is about as sentimental as a tractor"—and finished with a recommendation that Prokofiev uses "a light, witty touch" of Ravel to avoid heaviness and monotony (March 1, 1930).

The somewhat reserved reviews in America and in Paris were sweetened by the

enthusiastic reception Prokofiev received back in Russia, during his performance tour in 1927. Prokofiev's *Diary* of that year, compiled by Prokofiev from his shorthand notes and those of this wife, was found in Lina's belongings in 1989, and gives a very detailed account of Prokofiev's activities and meetings during his first trip to Russia since he left in 1918. Prokofiev performed the Second Piano Concerto three times during this memorable trip: on February 7 and March 20, 1927 in Moscow with Persimfans (a conductor-less orchestra with which he had already performed before leaving Russia), and on February 19 in Leningrad with Nikolai Malko. All of these concerts were tremendous successes and Prokofiev, having performed both the Third and Second Concertos for similar audiences within one week, said that the Second Concerto received a much more enthusiastic ovation. Unfortunately, first reactions of the trusted reviewers, Asafyev and Myaskovsky, to the revised version, were not preserved in writing or print.

Prokofiev kept performing the Second Piano Concerto until 1931 in a series of performances in London (1927), Brussels and Berlin (1930), and Vienna (1931). However, by 1934 he did not have it in his performing repertoire and refused invitations to perform the concerto, having been more focused on his compositional activities.

CHAPTER 4

INTRODUCTION TO THE HERMENEUTIC AND SEMIOTIC ANALYSIS OF PROKOFIEV'S SECOND PIANO CONCERTO

Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto is a rarity in the field of musical analysis. Despite its hundred years of existence, it has largely escaped the attention of music theorists and historians. The only strictly analytical passages devoted to this piece are in a monograph on all Prokofiev's concertos by Tadeusz Zielinski (1959), and in an article on "Prokofiev's Technique Of Chromatic Displacement" by Richard Bass (1988). Most of the literature on Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto comes from biographers, newspaper reviewers, and pianists who focus their attention on the historical, anecdotal and expressive aspects of the piece, but not its structure and inner workings. I will risk a hypothesis that it was a peculiar mix of modernity and traditionalism in the Second Piano Concerto that diminished its attractiveness to traditional structural analysts. The apparent "futuristic" traits, upon a closer look, firmly reveal traditional concepts rooted in Romantic music. Furthermore, the traits most strikingly evident in the piece—grandiose pathos, mockery and the grotesque—are elusive and difficult to pinpoint using traditional analytic tools. Richard Taruskin believes that Prokofiev's modernity is merely a cloak covering his true self as traditionalist and conformist:

> Not even the gawky, gangling young Prokofiev—whose early works horrified the squeamish Scriabin, and who attempted a rather callow emulation or maximization of *The Rite Of Spring* in his *Scythian Suite*, with its naively literalistic title—not even he could be called an avant-gardist. His loyalty, like Stravinsky's and like Scriabin's, was to the established elite culture. While he liked playing the part of an *enfant terrible*, he made sure that an academician

> could always detect his underlying allegiance to the traditional values and skills on which grades were based. This remained true throughout his life; it is utterly characteristic of Prokofiev that beneath the clangorous surface there always lay a simple harmonic design and stereotyped formal pattern straight out of the textbook. (1997, 86)

Even though Prokofiev's early music seems to ostensibly oppose the late romanticism of Rachmaninov and Medtner, it stems from the same tradition. Similarly, his music fell out of fashion when Europe and the United States embraced true modernism with its anti-romantic and anti-expressive values. Prokofiev, even when experimenting with dissonances and harsh sonorities, never joined the musical avant-garde. In contrast, Igor Stravinsky wrote in 1936: "I consider that music is, by its very nature, essentially powerless to express anything at all, whether a feeling, an attitude of mind, or psychological mood, a phenomenon of nature, etc….Expression has never been an inherent property of music. That is by no means the purpose of its existence" (53). Stravinsky's idea reflects a well-established tradition of "absolute" music, free of any extramusical content, exemplified in Hanslick's iconic statement: "The content of music is tonally moving forms" (Hanslick 1986, 29). Stravinsky's thoughts were echoed by Ned Rorem: "music . . . is inherently meaningless in the intellectual sense of the word" (Kramer 2002, 11). Such views by certain composers were also reflected by modern music theorists of the time, who perceived the meaning of music in its exclusively formal attributes. Modern music theory was predominantly structuralist. Kofi Agawu admits that there was a pressure to avoid "soft" analysis, attributed to music historians: "Analysts of a certain generation (and/or institutional provenance) were especially anxious to let it be known that the object of their research was the music itself; unlike music historians and as a matter of principle, they preferred to steer clear of the extraneous and the

extramusical" (2008, 5).

Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto is a product of late romanticism, with its reliance on the extramusical. All writings about this piece are evocative of strong expressive content and visual imagery. Traditional analysis, "understood as principally the study of the structure of music" (Palisca, 1980) is utterly inadequate in addressing such issues as irony, mockery and the grotesque—features that dominated Prokofiev's music of his early years. Furthermore, the musical structure alone cannot account for the piece's proclaimed "greater depth." To address these and other intricacies of the concerto, I will turn to new modes of analysis developed in the fields of musical semiotics and hermeneutics.

New Modes of Musical Analysis

The first Western recording of the Second Piano Concerto (Bolet, 1953) coincided with a renewed interest in the expressive qualities of music. Leonard B. Meyer, who brought attention to the opposition of "formalism" and "expressionism" in music, noted:

> …formalists would contend that the meaning of music lies in the perception and understanding of the musical relationships set forth in the work of art and that meaning in music is primarily intellectual, while the expressionist would argue that these same relationships are in some sense capable of exciting feelings and emotions in the listener. (Meyer 1956, 3)

Meyer's iconic *Emotion and Meaning in Music* was one of the first signs of a reversed tide occurring in music theory. In 1985 Joseph Kerman stirred the field of musicology by attacking the notion of autonomic music, and contributed to creating the New Musicology, which takes into account social and cultural circumstances surrounding a piece of music.

> Music's autonomous structure is only one of many elements that contribute to its import. Along with preoccupation with structure goes the neglect of other vital matters—not only the whole historical complex referred to above, but also everything else that makes music affective, moving, emotional, expressive. (Kerman 1985, 73)

By the 1990's "it became unwise to retain confidence in the reality of the notion of 'the music itself,' or to posit a categorical distinction between text and context, between the musical and the extramusical" (Agawu 2008, 5). In fact, the 1990's saw a rapid development of music semiotics. The groundwork for this new field was laid by Jean-Jacques Nattiez (1975) and Eero Tarasti (1978), who turned to Charles Sanders Peirce (1960) and his linguistic semiology in search for tools of decoding meaning in music. These first semiotic writings could be seen as an extension of a structuralist trend in music theory (both semiotics and structuralism trace their roots to the structural linguistics of Ferdinand de Saussure [1922]).

Leonard Ratner and Edward Cone, even though they did not claim an allegiance to semiotics, contributed significantly to the field: Ratner with his description of expressive gestures and stylistic conventions in the music of the eighteenth century (1985), and Cone by creating the idea of a musical persona (1974), which became an important element in discussions on narrativity of music. In the opening chapter of his book, *Classic Music* (1985), Ratner defines musical topics as forms with associative signification, and groups them into two categories: musical types (dances) and stylistic references (military and hunt music, fanfares, horn calls, singing and brilliant style, French overture, *Sturm und Drang*, sensibility, strict style, and fantasia). Kofi Agawu in *Playing with Signs* (1991), while conceding the methodological difficulties facing music semioticians and the magnitude of possible significations in music, designed a "semiotic

framework that not only accommodates but insists on the mutual interaction" between structure (perceived with Schenkerian tools) and expression (described with use of topical analysis revealing expressive gestures). In his view "introvertive semiosis" (structure) and "extravertive semiosis" (expression) are directly related, since each of the musical gestures or topics is presented with the use of a musical structure.

Robert Hatten (1994) developed a new theory, based partially on the topical theory of Ratner and Agawu. Hatten's important contributions included introducing concepts of markedness and troping, and more thorough take on musical gestures. In his view:

> Markedness deals with one dimension of musical meaning, that which arises from difference, in the Sausserian sense that meaning is difference. Difference implies opposition, but the oppositions that are characterized by markedness are typically *asymmetrical*: one term is marked (with the respect to some value or feature), and the opposing term (or field) is unmarked. (Hatten 2004, 11)

A trope involves combining typical material in atypical ways: "Like a metaphor in literary language, a trope is sparked from the collision or fusion of two already established meanings, and its interpretation is emergent." Troping seems to be one of Prokofiev's favorite tools—the Second Piano Concerto is saturated with tropes, which are partially responsible for the piece's early controversy and fickle relationship with critics and audiences. Hatten's theory was elaborated by Raymond Monelle (2000) and Robert Samuels (1995), who applied his methodology to nineteenth-century music. Re-infusion of musical topics, characters, or expressive types (which underlined most writings about music in the eighteenth century) into the theory of signification and narrativity allows us to decipher the meaning created by their fusion or juxtaposition.

The discursive, or narrative nature of music, has received much attention in the

last twenty years, resulting in vivid discussions on the appropriateness and ways of applying narrative theory to music. At first, the narrativists believed they needed literary or programmatic clues to justify a narrative structure. A recent article by Byron Almen shows that music narrative does not need to be "a transposed reflection of literary narrative" with its reliance on characters, plot and action (Almen 2003, 3). Instead, he proposes a "sibling model" in which "two media share a common foundation but varying manifestations." Michael Klein postulates: "If we wish to find in music a narrative impulse, we must look past the immediacy of the music as action, and attend to disruption, the clash of topics, and the mixing of genres in an intertextuality" (2005, 117). Such unexpected musical events, and moments of unfulfilled expectations provoke narrative speculations and provide clues for our inborn and natural need to narrate in order to deliver a logical explanation for puzzling situations.

The concept of narrativity may be linked to that of musical continuity, a major concern of performing artists. Even though both performers and music-analysts share profound closeness with the musical score, their readings and interpretations were executed in two parallel universes. Klein notices, "Beginning at least with Hugo Riemann and followed by Schenker, there are appeals to performers, whose woeful ignorance of matters music-analytic belies a disregard for deep and meaningful engagements with the score" (2005, 24). From the performer's point of view, however, the "anesthetizing" nature of structural analysis fails to contribute interpretative insights and "has surprisingly little to say about issues of interpretation" (Berry, 1989). The main concern of performers has been issues of temporal continuity and expression, which has not been addressed by structural analysis. The accusations of disregard for "deep and meaningful

engagement with score," although meritorious in some cases, miss the fact that analysis of the text alone, without the intertext and context, diminishes the depth and profundity of a musical experience.

Musical continuity, a cornerstone of every convincing interpretation, is—as musical narrativity—an elusive and multidimensional endeavor. It constitutes part of modern performing practice, relying mostly on verbal tradition in teaching studios, master classes and articles. Some of this tradition is recorded in the form of books written by performing musicians, audio and film recordings, or interviews. This rich tradition combines multiple sources—knowledge of the instruments and performing techniques, insights, intuitions, informal anecdotes and historical facts, all of which contribute to the reading of a musical work. Breathing life back into the printed text and reconstruction of continuity involves a thorough understanding of the musical narration. Some performers use poetic terms, some use visual imagery, some use theatrical analogies. More often than not, continuity is born out of the variety of insights and representations that are inspired by the text, and enlivened by the performer's imagination. Thanks to the revival of the theory of narrativity and musical gesture, the parallel universes of performance and musical analysis have begun to merge and infuse each other with their individual expertise.

Musical analysis in recent years has undergone a significant transformation. In Klein's view, the structuralist analysis of the mid-twentieth century "anesthetizes the breathing music, making of it a sculpture that the musician can walk around in order to calculate distances" (Klein 2005, 24). Such analysis, even when it is given a status of a musical behavior, fails to adequately inform a performer's interpretative decisions. By

contrast, Agawu proposes a new model of analysis grounded in his interest in the confluence of composition, performance, and analysis:

> But what if we conceive of analysis as a mode of performance, or as a mode of composing, not as an unveiling of resident truths, not as an exercise in decoding? What if we think of the truth of a musical work as emerging from doing, from engaging with musical materiality, and not as a summary narrative that is produced after the doing? What if we think of analysis as a means to an unspecified end, a flexibly conceived end that may range from making relatively trivial observations about style and history to the less trivial pleasure of inhabiting the composition's space for prolonged periods and engaging in diverse ways with its elements? (Agawu 2008, 5)

An important turn in the perception of the role of the musical analysis was brought by raising the issues of subjectivity.

> For most of the twentieth century, subjectivity, in the sense of the private monad, was regarded as an obstacle to both musical experience and musical knowledge. Too much emphasis on feeling or ascription of meaning could only obscure what was truly musical about music, its articulation of style, form, and structure. (Kramer 2003, 6)

Instead of a finalized and objective reading of a given piece, embodied by "system and structure, objectivity, detached observation, hard evidence and literal description," Kramer postulates a new set of analytical tools: "process and practice, subjectivity, participant observation, suggestive evidence and metaphor." Even more tellingly, he stands in defense of unsystematic and accidental perceptions of music, which "carry with them our intuitive, precritical sense of the world" (2011, 66). Similarly, Marion Guck proposes that music analysis can be viewed as interpretation, rather than a conclusive and objective description:

> My idea of interpretation depends on the everyday sense in which things are "open to interpretation," the sense in which interpretation is accounting for something that might be taken in a number of ways, or the sense in which one tries to put one's finger on something difficult to pin down. I want to emphasize as well the notion of personal account that is inherent in interpretation. (2006, 194)

Such views of modern analysts are mirrored by a contemporary pianist who wrote:

> Essays resemble performances in that their ambition is open-ended. I like to see both of them, at least potentially, as works in progress, to be reconsidered and, if possible improved. In the face of masterworks, I try to understand what they are instead of telling them - and the audience - what they should be…To perceive music as a succession of masterful exceptions rather than a chessboard of idiosyncrasies will keep the performer young and the wonders of his tasks never ending. (Brendel 2000, 3)

Kramer, Klein, Agawu and Guck, among others, contribute to their analyses—seen as discourse, or interpretation, or performance—their experiences as musicians and composers, bridging the gap between analysis and performance, and linking them genealogically to other writers whose perception of music was informed by their active musicianship: Donald Tovey, Charles Rosen, Edward T. Cone.

Goals and Findings of the Analysis of the Second Piano Concerto

In my analysis of Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto I will freely use elements of musical hermeneutics and semiotics, as well as narrative theory. The puzzling nature of this piece invites a multidisciplinary approach. Even though the following analysis does not adhere to a singular trend in semiotic thought, it is still unique in its attempt to analyze the entire piece in terms of evocative meaning. Through its long history, the Second Piano Concerto provoked strong emotional reactions in the listeners and performers alike. The goal of the following analysis will be to uncover the means used by Prokofiev in creation of the proclaimed “greater depth,” and intertextual sublayers which contribute to the puzzling and often ambiguous nature of the piece. Furthermore, the analysis of the contextual and intertextual meaning will reveal how performance tradition had influenced the reading of the piece's ambiguities, and how occasionally it contradicts

the score's semiotic content and composer's indications. Most importantly, I will show how Prokofiev's tendency toward irony and mockery is reflected in musical form.

While the issues of irony and the grotesque in music have received somewhat more attention in recent years, it is still a pioneering field. This monograph owes much to works of Esti Sheinberg (2001) and Julie Brown (2007), who discussed issues of irony and the grotesque in works of Shostakovich and Bartók, respectively. Sheinberg noted that the grotesque (which she classifies as subtype of irony) was omnipresent in Russia in the first twenty years of the twentieth century. Irony has been commonly used as a tool of dissent toward higher authority and may be interpreted as an intellectual defensive mechanism in face of political and social instability and uncertainty. The fact that Russian society has been subjected to a high degree of censorship, first of the Tsarist and then Soviet regime, may explain irony's firm grasp on Russian culture. Even though Prokofiev's later political stance—or lack of thereof—provoked much criticism, in his student years he exhibited a strong inclination of dissent toward the higher authority embodied by the professors of the St. Petersburg Conservatory.

Richard Taruskin sees Prokofiev as an opportunist who bowed to the established hierarchy by employing traditional forms and romantically rooted conventions, and following rules to earn the praise of the authorities. However, Prokofiev's use of irony and mockery can be seen as a sign of his defiance. His adherence to an older style was not necessarily a sign of conformism. Quite the opposite, he shrewdly exhibited his understanding of composition according to the requirements of the Conservatory while treating his material with an ironic twist. Irony's ambiguous character is the safest way of dissent. Political irony was very often left overlooked and uncensored. Reading

Prokofiev's Second Concerto as an ironic statement significantly changes its current perception and opens new possibilities for interpretation.

The following analysis will show that irony is a common tool used by Prokofiev throughout all four movements of the Concerto. On a micro level, it shows in the troping of incongruous themes and motives, and in using established formulas in a parodistic fashion. On the other hand, Prokofiev's failure to build a convincing and unified multi-movement form reflects a new tendency in the twentieth-century music. Lawrence Kramer argues:

> From roughly the mid-eighteenth to the turn of the twentieth century, roughly, again, from Bach to Mahler, both of whom are equivocal examples, music tends to assume a certain narrativity as inherent to its movement in time. The narrativity thus assumed is relatively, even largely, free of irony…. Music in the twentieth century tends to break down this narrative regime, which, however, never disappears entirely. The narrative impetus tends to become ironic, and the ironic detachment shades into objectification." (Kramer 2013, 166)

The Second Piano Concerto comprises four unrelated movements. Rather then establishing a narrative continuum, Prokofiev presents them as separate and contrasting *tableaux.* Each of the movements features a new and independent stylistic vision. The first movement, saturated with Romantic pathos and musical allusions to death, dominates the impression of the entire concerto. The following *Scherzo* and *Intermezzo* try to counterbalance the tragic tone of the opening movements with mockery and the grotesque, while the closing *Finale* relies on a Russian lullaby to impose a more earnest tone. Still, the concluding passages in the *Finale*'s Coda contradict the sincerity of this movement, and the concerto ends with a ridiculously sounding and hardly resolved cacophony.

The following analysis draws inspiration from many works of semioticians and music theorists. Its pluralistic and free approach to analytic techniques is dictated by the author's belief that searching for meaning in music is an open-ended and inclusive process. Anything and everything that may contribute to a deeper understanding of a piece of music is worth attention and exploration. The final effect of such a pursuit is not a final and definite version, just one of the steps leading to a more complete and fulfilling experience of the music.

CHAPTER 5

ANDANTINO: THE STORY BEHIND AND THE STORY WITHIN

Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto is marked by unusual occurrences, atypical formal structures and a strongly dramatic content, which may have contributed to the perseverance of the idea that this piece is a representation of Schmidthof's tragic ending. To a certain degree Prokofiev invited story-telling speculations by marking the *Andantino*'s first theme *Narrante*, which I take as permission to analyze this movement from a topical and narrative perspective.

Prokofiev was a master of combining classical techniques with modern innovations; the Second Concerto is an example of his extraordinary ability to use traditional compositional tools, like topics, and romantically rooted harmonic and formal conventions. The sonata-allegro form of the *Andantino* is strongly modified: the second theme is not repeated in the recapitulation nor included in the development; the development is presented as a solo cadenza, and the extremely shortened recapitulation is based on the introductory phrase, repeated in an ostinato fashion. Prokofiev refreshes the classical concept of dualism, but does not confine it to the formal principle. In the allegro sonata of the first movement, each of the two themes is based on an inner topical dichotomy, creating a sense of uneasiness and friction within the themes themselves. From the first measures the movement fails to fulfill listeners' expectations, which may have triggered the premiere's turmoil. Charles Rosen believes:

> It is not the unfamiliarity or strangeness of a composer's manner that is a bar to understanding, but rather the disappearance of the familiar, the ongoing disappointment of the expectations and hopes fostered by the musical tradition in which we have grown up. Not novelty, therefore, but the absence of something

> recognizable in its style, its language—something we once thought essential to music—makes listening to a radically original work a test we are likely to fail. (Rosen 1994, 4)

Eerie and vague pizzicatos in the orchestral introduction fail to establish a tonal context or a melodic theme in the traditional sense (Figure 5.1). This unremarkable introduction (which I will call "motive x") tends to be easily forgotten as soon as the first theme starts. However, in the formal and narrative structure of the piece it proves to be of great significance. Although motive x is harmonically ambiguous, there is a clear suggestion of a Neapolitan chord in the second measure, an unmistakable instance of *ombra,* a topic established in the 18th century and described by Ratner (1985). Besides the suggested Neapolitan harmony, the eeriness and emptiness (rests, octaves) of motive x, and especially its subsequent repetitions, which take on a sinister and apocalyptic quality, point to the concept of the uncanny (*unheimliche*). The term was initially coined by Freud in 1919 as un umbrella for an "obsessional inventory of eerie fantasies, motifs, and effects, an itemized tropology of the weird" (Castle 1995, 4). In the following decades it became widely used in discussions of aesthetics and philosophy, representing the idea of "the repressed familiar to emanate in a strangely defamiliarized form" (Cohn 2004, 287). Klein uses the concept of the uncanny to explain the narrative logic in Chopin's Piano Sonata in B-flat minor: the uncanny enharmonic progression of the introduction spurs "obsessive compulsive action in recoil of the enharmonic rupture" and subsequently leads to the "disintegration of subjectivity" in the last movement (2005, 95). Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto will reveal quite a few conceptual borrowings from Chopin's Piano Sonata in B-flat minor, which he coincidentally studied during his work on the concerto. One of them is the concept of the uncanny return, another is the weaving

together the codes of the uncanny and death. Even though unusual, Prokofiev's sparse concerto introduction bears a similarity with the opening bars of the Piano Concerto by Rimski-Korsakov (which Prokofiev admired and played a few years prior) (Figure 5.2.).



Figure 5.1. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Andantino*. An introduction.



Figure 5.2. N. Rimski-Korsakov: Piano Concerto, Op. 30. *Moderato.* An introduction. (M.P. Belaieff [Leipzig] 1886. Public domain)

Both introductions feature motives unrelated to the thematic material, soft dynamics and detached articulation, and similar orchestration (strings and a single woodwind instrument). While Rimski-Korsakov's orchestral staccatos lead directly to an orchestral

outburst in a massive *tutti,* Prokofiev's piano takes over in an unusually discreet way: a nocturnal accompanying figure pointing intertextually to Chopin's nocturnes and his *Andante Spianato.* When the right hand joins in, it presents the first theme in a contrasting character and rhythm: the pastoral character established by the left hand (wavelike arpeggiations, empty fifths, slow harmonic rhythm, quiet dynamics, 12-8 pulse) is juxtaposed with horn-like calls of the right hand's melody (pianists sometimes try to minimize the dichotomy of the first theme by modifying the dotted rhythm to comply with the triplets in an 18th-century fashion). While both parts share a similar intervallic structure, their contrasting character puts them on semiotic antipodes: the nocturnal character of the accompaniment is associated with a private sphere, while the melody, saturated with jumps and dotted rhythms, through its associations with marches, signifies a public and military realm. Chopin used dotted rhythms sporadically in the melodic lines of his nocturnes; the intervallic shape and persistency of the dotted figures in Prokofiev's theme reminds one of the introduction to Chopin's *Fantasia*, which represents a march. In 1913, an annoyed reviewer described the "bewildering" effect of Prokofiev's opening statements as "wiping the keyboard or testing the keys" (Nice 2003, 97). It is quite possible that the whole opening was barely heard in the outdoor setting of the Pavlovsk summer concert. The reviewer adds another clue: "all this is done with dry, sharp touch" (Nice 2003, 97). Hence, the "unfamiliar" opening contradicted expectations in two ways—first by a lack of a strong statement or decisive contrast, then, by a perceived lack of a lyrical theme. The audience promptly reacted to the troping of two incongruous topics. The first theme's rhythmic shape has more in common with the march movements of Mahler's Symphonies, or the French Overture topic, than the

nocturnal-pastoral character of the left hand's line. A dysphoric rhythm, the uneasy melodic shape of the theme (wide melodic intervals, short ascending [aspiring] and longer descending [resigned] motivic directions), combined with the tragically charged G minor key provoke suspicion that the presupposed idyll is too unstable to last. The next section, the first theme group marked *caloroso con gran espressione* seems to provide an explanation for the previous uneasy narration. Assuming that the *narrante* indicates a presence of a narrator in the first theme, he appears initially as an objective storyteller, who tries to hide unpleasant elements of his story (but couldn't help that some of them snuck-in), while in the *caloroso* we hear an account of someone directly affected. The directness and determination of the ascending line lead to the short-lasting climax in B minor, but the assertive mood is quickly replaced by doubt (Figure 5.3): the melodic line is trapped in repetitions of third-based motives, unable to move forward. The pastoral entrance of the flutes and clarinets pacifies the chromatically charged chordal build-up; this pastoral intervention is supposed to bring back the initial calm, and it succeeds, but not for long.

As the *Caloroso* section returns, it is strengthened by the first repression. Now the pianist manages to convince the orchestra to share his point of view (both orchestra and piano play the *caloroso* theme, while the first time the pianist played solo), which leads to the first joint climax. The climactic surge dissolves quickly, leading to a transitional passage toward the second theme group (the transition is based on the C-sharp pedal note: an unlikely harmonic place in G minor).

The second theme group, as expected, brings a change of character (*con eleganza*) and key (ii, A minor). The second theme is an example of Prokofiev's favorite dance topic—the gavotte, which he used extensively throughout his life (Figure 5.4). Despite the change of character, the second theme fails to provide an adequate counterbalance to the first section's tragic tone; Prokofiev's insistence on using a subdominant key area and *pianto* motives, combined with off-beat *sforzatos*, leave little room for hope that the initial drama will resolve happily. Prokofiev's predilection for contrasting and juxtaposing different topics shows itself in R. 8-9, where he layers the gavotte theme with virtuosic passages in the piano. The second appearance of the second theme is even more dysphoric: now virtuosic quasi-glissandos are layered with *piantos* (R. 14, Figure 5.5).



Figure 5.3. *Andantino*. The first theme group.



Figure 5.4. *Andantino*. The second theme (R. 7)

As I will show in the analysis of the *Intermezzo*, the glissando figures were commonly associated in the Russian musical tradition with the supernatural and exotic and, as such, belonged to the sphere of story telling and fantasy. The *pianto* motives,

when used in accordance with their original topos, represent an emotional pain. When combined together in a trope associated with a dance topic, they point to an ironic detachment of an amused observer.



Figure 5.5. *Andantino*. The second theme. Troping of *piantos* and *glissandos* (R. 14)

Eventually, the second-theme group ends in an angry outburst that contradicts its initial elegant and reserved tone. The closing theme (R. 17) brings back the uncertainty of the doubting section and the chromaticism of the yearning topic but now stripped of any hope and driving energy. Time stops for a moment in the orchestral transition, and this

quiet moment yields an opportunity for the narrator to reintroduce the first theme: the development section in the form of an extensive solo cadenza begins with sweet innocence (*dolce*, R. 20). Starting from this point, the orchestra is silent for 66 measures (a third of the entire movement's length), while the pianist, embodying the part of a romantic hero, struggles with the simultaneous presentation of themes being previously divided between the piano and orchestra. The length and enormous size of this cadenza is the most striking of the first movement, although not without a precedent in Russian music: Tchaikovsky's *Fantaisie de Concert*, Op.56, a little-known piece for piano and orchestra in two movements. The middle part of the first movement consists of a highly virtuosic, multi-sectional cadenza, whose technical demands, and size (156 measures, 12 minutes long) dwarf by far the cadenzas of Tchaikovsky's Piano Concertos. This unusual cadenza employs all the virtuosic tools Tchaikovsky had at his disposal: cascades of parallel octaves, chordal progressions, a Lisztian balancing of several concurrent lines, emphatic interruptions, and filigree arabesques complementing a sustained melody in a lower voice. Prokofiev elaborated on many of these technical aspects, excluding with distaste all instances of "routine passages;" in Prokofiev's cadenza, the virtuosity is always in service of an intended expressive effect rather than flashy expose.

After the re-exposition of the main theme in a densely contrapuntal texture, the yearning topic reappears and it succeeds in overcoming doubt and apathy; as a result it heroically elevates the first theme to a major mode (m. 133). Encouraged by this success and in pursuit of a desired dominant function, the theme climbs yet two more times—the second time to A major, which places it close to the dominant, D major. The third reappearance, prepared by a D9 chord, reaches an augmented D-flat chord, instead of the

expected tonic, triggering a dramatic fall that resembles a chordal avalanche. At the bottom of that dramatic fall awaits motive x from the introduction, but this time in a form of sinister accents (Figure 5.6), as if fulfilling Freud's definition of the uncanny: "the uncanny is something that was once known to us, but has been repressed and forgotten; in a later mental stage any reappearance of the repressed material seems new and terrifying" (Klein 2005, 78). This reappearance is unexpected and terrifying, and results in a panic-stricken *precipitato* and harmonic confusion of the subsequent passages.



Figure 5.6. *Andantino*. *Cadenza*. Uncanny returns (motive x).

The motives of the first theme are scattered between both hands, as if the narrator tried unsuccessfully to find his objective voice. The heavy swinging of dotted-rhythm figures in this section (mm. 144–153) points iconically to the swinging of bells; the bell-like gestures have accompanied the reappearance of motive x in m. 139, and they will be prominent in the consequent passages of the cadenza. An extended harmonic sequence culminates in the apotheosis of the *caloroso* theme, marked *colossale* (m. 154); it

succeeds in overcoming doubt, plaguing its previous appearances, by modulation to E minor, and reinstating the full theme in this new tonal area. Prokofiev employs his layering technique here again: the *caloroso* theme is accompanied by motives from the first theme, used as bell gestures. An enormous build-up transforms the doubting figures into incessant calls. Now for the first time one hears a striking similarity between those calls, based on an interval of a third, and the third-based motives of motive x, despite the fact that we hear those thirds in a reversed order. The important modification is that instead of a presumed C minor tonality (E-flat going to C), the music moves to A major (E/C-sharp), giving us hope that eventually we may hear the dominant harmony.

A tumultuous accelerated surge provokes a silent orchestra to participate: it presents an apocalyptic version of motive x in a deafening *tutti* with the leading sonorities of trombones and tuba. While listening to the breathtaking austerity of that sudden intervention, one has an uncanny feeling that the tune is familiar, not only from the preceding ten minutes. Even though Prokofiev does not quote the *Dies irae* (Figure 5.7) nor does he preserve its modal harmonic content, the impression of a correlation is unmistakably evoked by a similar melodic contour, as well as arresting instrumentation, augmented rhythm and volume. After Hector Berlioz included the *Dies irae* in his *Symphony fantastique*, it had become "a standard *objet de fantasie*" (Taruskin 1997, 279) employed by a number of composers: Berlioz, Liszt, Saint-Saens, Tchaikovsky (Orchestral Suite No. 3, *Manfred*), Rachmaninov (Symphony No. 2, *The Isle of the Dead*, *Rhapsody on a theme by Paganini*), Mussorgsky (*Trepak* in *Songs and dances of Death*, *Night on a Bald Mountain*) and Stravinsky (*The Rite of Spring*), among others. However, while Berlioz and Liszt quoted the chant as a prominent theme, Russian composers often

only alluded to it. Tchaikovsky's Orchestral Suite No. 3, Op. 55 gives a parodistic hint of the *Dies Irae* in the fourth of the last movement's variations. Prokofiev, like Rachmaninov and Mussorgsky, uses just an opening motive of the chant, and supplies an instrumentation characteristic of a "dance of death"—with low-register brass and percussion—to complement the effect.



Figure 5.7. *Dies irae* (from Grove Dictionary)

The striking reappearance of motive x marks the beginning of a short recapitulation comprised of four appearances of that motive (David Nice points out that this "telescopic development" was inspired by Rachmaninov's Third Piano Concerto [Nice, 2003]). Remarkably, the terrifying apparition fails to induce panic. To the contrary: the pianist, encouraged and strengthened by heroic deeds of the development not only faces the uncanny as an equal but also supports it harmonically. Qualities that initially constructed the uncanny in its narrative function—eeriness, vagueness, and emptiness—are annihilated by the pianist's harmonic accompaniment. The unknown becomes known and familiar, and as such does not induce terror. In addition, eventually we hear the dominant harmony, dominating the first part of the recapitulation; presumed at the beginning, the subdominant and Neapolitan harmonies disappear (even the third C/E-flat appears to be the 7th and 9th of the dominant chord). The final section brings complete reconciliation of the previous adversaries: the first theme is commented on by motive x, but neither of them prevails. As the fear of the unknown has been annihilated, they can now coexist,

like old enemies dying together after a long fight. From the perspective of this ending, both themes appear inseparable, as yin and yang, light and shadow, life and death.

"We tell stories," writes Klein (2004, 23). A story organizes events into a comprehensible and logical continuum. The story within Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto helps explain the formal aberrations of the first movement. The second-theme group failed to provide narrative balance to the uncanny and the first theme; it disintegrated within itself by failing to uphold its elegant character, and as such it proved useless for further development. The solo cadenza manifests the loneliness of the musical persona in dealing with its fears. It is the development of inner strength and overcoming of doubt (modulation to E minor) that allows this persona to succeed in facing the full strength of the uncanny. Prokofiev pursued his goal of composing a concerto of a "greater depth" by a masterly manipulation of musical tools used traditionally to portray death: chromaticism, minor tonality, subdominant and Neapolitan harmonies, dichotomous and dysphoric themes. The assumption that this masterpiece's musical form and expression was shaped by personal experiences does a great injustice to Prokofiev's compositional talent.

CHAPTER 6

SCHERZO. STUDY IN MOCKERY

Prokofiev was a stark denunciator of musical borrowing and slavish imitation of other composers. Still, he was a prudent student of his predecessors, and, while avoiding imitation, he drew from tradition more than he was willing to admit. An analysis reveals that this movement's content is intertextually connected to a group of fantastic *scherzo*s, which draw inspiration from mythological sources, as well as from nature. By parodistic transformation of the last movement of Chopin's Piano Sonata in B-flat minor, Prokofiev distances himself from the Romantic idiom. In the layer of rhythmic ostinato, Prokofiev shows genealogical kinship with Glinka's *Kamarinskaya* and other pieces based on Russian folk dances. The combination of these hardly congruous layers creates a sense of good-humored play.

Prokofiev's inherent “acrobatic tendencies” are strikingly apparent in the *Scherzo*. To Israel Nestyev this “highly complicated” movement resembles a primitive dance (1961, 74). To Harlow Robinson, its “infectiously optimistic” perpetual motion reminds one of “relentless force and fluidity of a speeding locomotive” (1987, 97). Pianists who reflect on the second movement, while admitting its lighter character and emotional relief in a series of separate movements, also highlight the technical challenges. Prokofiev himself proposed a lengthy break between the first and second movements, explaining that “after the exhausting cadenza it is physically impossible to go straight on and play the even more demanding scherzo” (Prokofiev 2006, 487). Barbara Nissman concedes, “Even though functioning as a lighter diversion meant to cleanse the palette, this

demanding second movement scherzo provides a real tour-de-force with its sharp wit and jabbing accents" (Nissman 2002, para.2). Aleksander Toradze compares the beginning to a coachman lashing his horses (Toradze 1998, 10). David Nice, in turn, notices that its toccata style is "more dazzling good fun than menacing obsession" (2003, 97).

Like the *Andantino*, the *Scherzo* is marked by unusual occurrences. Its monolithic form and perpetual motion in incessant parallel octaves between the hands have no precedent in the concerto repertoire. However, upon a closer look, it becomes evident that Prokofiev follows well–established traditions, despite blurring the listeners' ears with his innovative harmonic and textural strokes. The unique texture of the piano part is borrowed from Chopin's Sonata in B-flat minor (Figure 6.1), which Prokofiev studied for Esipova's piano class right at the time of composing his Second Piano Concerto. Artur Rubinstein's famous anecdotal description of this movement compares Chopin's effect to "wind howling around the gravestones."[7] Toradze, addressing this intertextuality, thinks that Prokofiev is "fleeing the graveyard rather than staying there" (Toradze 1998, 10). Where Chopin asks for legato, Prokofiev's texture invites detached articulation[8]; where Chopin's highly chromatic arabesques elude a sense of tonality, Prokofiev firmly establishes the key by four measures of static D minor, reinforced by empty fifths in the strings. Prokofiev anticipates any accusation of Chopin's influence by stripping the original version of its intertextual significance. He does not imitate, rather he mocks in a sarcastic fashion (Figure 6.2).

[7] Although this anecdote is commonly repeated, I have been unable to track down the comment to its original source (the story may be apocryphal).

[8] Even though Chopin did not ask for the use of the pedal until the last notes, Charles Rosen brings to our attention that Anton Rubinstein and Sergei Rachmaninov washed this movement in heavy pedal, in support of its traditionally perceived meaning (Rosen 1994, 298). Very likely, Prokofiev was most familiar with this tradition.

Esti Steinberg notes that while parody usually distorts the alluded style by its exaggeration, a musical satire "is concerned with the assessment of certain musical phenomena...against a musical, aesthetic and/or ethical set of norms, and with the implied demand for their rectification" (2000, 77). Prokofiev's distaste for Chopin's hegemony in the concert repertoire is well known. As a 17-year-old student he told his friends with his typical contrariness: "They say that you can't give a piano recital without Chopin. I will prove that we can do quite well without Chopin!" (Nestyev 1961, 39). Eventually, after studying more of his music, Prokofiev embraced Chopin as a composer, learning and performing several of his pieces on a tour in the United States and even reported that he "enjoyed greatly" playing his music. However, in 1913 Prokofiev saw Chopin as an embodiment of Romantic self-indulgence, and he resorted to musical satire to voice his objection.



Figure 6.1. F. Chopin: Piano Sonata in B-flat minor, Op. 35. *Finale. Presto.* (C.F. Peters [Leipzig], 1879. Public Domain)



Figure 6.2. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto in G minor, Op. 16. *Scherzo* (R. 26-27).

Musical satirization, a subset of irony, depends on stylistic norms to expose and satirize broader esthetic and cultural values. Prokofiev's sarcastic transformation of a blurry legato into toccata-like staccato, and gloomy chromaticism into clear diatonicism seems to object to the entire romantic idiom. In a similar fashion, Prokofiev's "Classical" Symphony fits a category of musical sarcasm by mocking not only classical tonality, but also "the broader value of cultural rhetoric" (Sheinberg 2001, 77 quoting Ratner 1980, 33–37, 107–108).

Despite the unusual form and pianistic texture, the *Scherzo* movement of the Second Piano Concerto follows a long tradition of fantastic *scherzo*s, reaching genealogically from Stravinsky, Rimski-Korsakov and Glinka to Berlioz and Mendelssohn. As quoted above, semiotically oriented descriptions of this movement range from "a speeding locomotive" to "lashing horses," but strangely no one heard the most obvious iconic imitation: the sound of a flying insect. One can blame a tradition of muscular playing of this movement. David Nice muses that the Concerto's solo part was "made for the big-boned offspring of the Russian piano school" (2003, 95), which drowns the orchestral nuances, and turns this lightweight joke into a monstrous giant. The buzzing sound of the piano part is gradually transformed into whirling arabesques, while pizzicatos of the violins and muted bassoons create an eerie and translucent accompaniment. Occasional horn calls add to this fairly fairy-tale landscape. Interestingly, Prokofiev admits changing his initial dynamic plan (which calls for occasional *fortissimo),* succumbing to Myaskovsky's advice and performing the entire movement "absolutely piano" (Prokofiev 2006, 487).

Francesca Brittan provides a convincing argument that a strand of the *scherzo*

movements in the nineteenth and early twentieth century "have a long history of association with nineteenth-century fairy music" and reveal "the centrality of the fantastic as a musical category" (2011, 529). This group of *scherzo*s, which French critics labeled *scherzo fantastique,* includes *scherzo* from Mendelssohn's *Octet*, Op. 20 and the incidental music to *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, as well as Berlioz's *La Reine Mab*, and Stravinsky's *Scherzo fantastique*, Op. 3, which premiered in St. Petersburg in January of 1909. Fanny Mendelssohn links "the ethereal, fanciful, and spirit-like" *scherzo* of her brother's *Octet*, Op. 20 (1825) to the Walpurgisnacht Dream of Goethe's *Faust*, "a fanciful episode in which Ariel, Puck, and a host of other airborne fairies perform a masquerade in celebration of the Golden Anniversary of Oberon and Titania" (Brittan 2011, 527). Mendelssohn's Overture to *A Midsummer Night's Dream* featured a similar "gossamer soundscape generated by rapid, staccato strings and pointillistic winds" (Brittan 2011, 527). Other features of the fairy-style, or simply fantastic *scherzo* are fast tempi and light textures.

The supernatural and imaginary often has been blended with sounds of the natural world—in particular, sounds of flying insects. Mendelssohn's friend shares a moment observed when the composer was working on the Overture to *A Midsummer Night's Dream*.

> The weather was beautiful, and we were engaged in animated conversation as we lay in the shade on the grass when, all of a sudden, he seized me firmly by the arm, and whispered: "Hush!" He afterwards informed me that a large fly had just then gone buzzing , and he wanted to hear the sound it produced gradually die away. When the Overture was completed, he showed me the passage in the progression, where the violoncello modulates in the chord of the seventh of a descending scale from B minor to F-sharp minor, and said: "There, that's the fly that buzzed past us at Schönhauser!" (Brittan 2011, 539)

Accidentally or not, the bassoons and oboes in Prokofiev's *Scherzo* mimic Mendelssohn's cello fly from *A Midsummer Night's Dream* (Figures 6.3 and 6.4). Portraying the aforementioned fly with a cello gives a good idea about its size, and even brings into consideration another insect, much closer to Prokofiev's musical home—a bumble bee.

Undoubtedly Prokofiev had no intention of portraying a bumble bee—not after Rimski-Korsakov's famous operatic interlude. Even without supporting verbal evidence, the swirling and buzzing turns of the piano part offer enough proof that Prokofiev's *Scherzo* stems directly from the Mendelssohnian *scherzo fantastique* style.

The blending of supernatural, fantastic, and entomological elements appears also in Berlioz's *Queen Mab Scherzo*.

> …for Berlioz, as for Mendelssohn, insects occupied the same imaginative space as fairies. The humming and buzzing figures that dominate Mab's music evoked for the composer and his listeners both the entomological realm under the magnifying glass and the fictional world of Queen Mab. (Brittan, p.22)

Richard Taruskin declares that Berlioz extended a pronounced influence over Glinka's *Fantaisies pittoresques* (Taruskin 1997, 115). In turn, Berlioz praised Glinka for his use of Russian folk tunes.



Figure 6.3. F. Mendelssohn: An Overture to *A Midsummer Night's Dream,* Op. 21 (Muzgiz [Moscow] 1960. Public domain)



Figure 6.4. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Scherzo*. An opening.

One of its three movements, *Kamarinskaya* (Figure 6.5) is based on two Russian folk melodies: a wedding song and a dance song. Taruskin points out that *kamarinskaya* is only one of "the well defined group of Russian folk *naigrishi*, or instrumental dance tunes" which, by the enormous influence of Glinka on Russian music, were widely adopted by other composers. Tchaikovsky believed that *Kamarinskaya* constituted the core of the entire school of Russian symphonic music:

> How astonishingly beautiful is his *Kamarinskaya*, from which all the Russian composers who followed him (including myself) continue to this day to borrow contrapuntal and harmonic combinations directly (when) they have to develop a Russian dance-tune! This is done unconsciously; but the fact is, Glinka managed to concentrate in one short work what a dozen second-rate talents would only have invented with the whole expenditure of their powers… Without intending to compose anything beyond a simple, humorous trifle, he has left us a little masterpiece, every bar of which is the outcome of enormous creative power. Half a century has passed since then, and many Russian symphonic works have been composed; we may even speak of a symphonic school. Well? The germ of all this lies in *Kamarinskaya*, as the oak tree lies in the acorn. For long years to come Russian composers will drink at this source, for it will need much time and much strength to exhaust its wealth of inspiration. (Tchaikovsky 1973, pp. 377, 564)

Kamarinskaya had a particular meaning to young Prokofiev, as he received its score from the director of the Petersburg Conservatory with a priceless inscription: "To my dear colleague Seryozha Prokofiev from A. Glazunov." Prokofiev, who studied this score in depth in the spring of 1913, remarked with disbelief: "To think that once upon a time I was on such terms with Glazunov!" (Prokofiev 2006, 357).

Kamarinskaya may well be at the core of Prokofiev's humoristic side. As much as he disliked labeling his music "grotesque," he offered alternate ways of understanding humor in his music:

> I strenuously object to the very word "grotesque" which has become hackneyed to the point of nausea…I would prefer my music to be described as "scherzo-ish" in quality, or else by three words describing the various degrees of the scherzo—whimsicality, laughter, mockery. (1992, 249)

As much as Prokofiev's early piano *scherzos* exemplify the toccata line, the instrumental ones can be linked to Glinka's orchestral piece in their frequent employment of staccato sound and ostinato patterns (Figure 6.6).



Figure 6.5. N. Glinka: *Kamarinskaya.* (M.P. Belaieff [Leipzig] 1902. Public domain)



Figure 6.5. S. Prokofiev: *Scherzo humoristique*, Op. 12bis (Jurgenson [Moscow] 1915. Public domain)

The homogenous formal structure of Prokofiev's *Scherzo* is a result of an uninterrupted pianistic stream of notes blurring the distinctions between the sections. However, a score analysis reveals the existence of a trio, which is almost impossible to discern while listening. Prokofiev reports with typical honesty that during the premiere, "In the Trio I again became nervous and made mistakes, but after running up and down some chromatic scales instead of my written passages I quickly got back on track, so that nobody noticed the blunder" (Prokofiev 2006, 488). While the piano continues its perpetual motion in the Trio, the orchestra breaks the rhythmic ostinato of repetitions and offers more variety, albeit within the regular four bar phrasing. The rhythmic outline of the orchestra part resembles an opening of another Prokofiev's *scherzo*—that of his Second Piano Sonata (Figures 6.7 and 6.8). Appropriately in a *scherzo* trio, this rhythmic outline comes from a *rigaudon*, a dance Prokofiev favored in his young years.



Figure 6.7. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Sonata, Op. 28. *Scherzo* (Dover Publications, 2002)



Figure 6.8. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Scherzo*. Trio. (2-piano reduction of the orchestral score. Boosey&Hawkes 1947)

The opening of the Trio offers delightful proof of Prokofiev's prankish mockery: the interjecting harmonics on the second beat of the dance rhythm are borrowed from Rimski-Korsakov's orchestral poem *Antar*. In the *Diaries* Prokofiev mentioned examining "how the sound of arrows being loosed" was achieved in *Antar*, as he envisioned using a similar effect in the *Scherzo* (2006, 355). In *Antar* the arrow effect is employed in the middle of the *Furioso* section of the first movement, depicting a hunting scene in the midst of an Arabian desert (Figure 6.9). Prokofiev transplanted this effect along with its signifying power. Interjecting the elegance of a French court dance with a symbol of a primitive and bloody enterprise is shocking in its extreme incongruity, but also as ridiculous as a moustache on Mona Lisa's face (Figure 6.10).



Figure 6.9. N. Rimski-Korsakov: Symphony No. 2 *Antar* (1903). *Largo*. The "arrow effect." (Muzgiz [Moscow] 1949)



Figure 6.10. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Scherzo*. Trio. The "arrow effect."

Right at the center of the movement, revealed as in a babushka set, the Trio unveils another little trio section in A-flat major (the diminished Dominant of the home key), where the piano part becomes completely tonal, and the orchestra is based on imitative exchanges. Imitation, being exemplary of the "high" or "learned" style, is highlighted by its central position within the movement, but also stripped of its traditional associations with "seriousness and authoritativeness" (Hatten 2004, 198). Rather, in

another example of mockery, Prokofiev cheerfully ridicules the virtues of hierarchy and order associated with an old school of composition.

In the shortened reprise Prokofiev interspersed motives of the outer sections and the trio, never letting the pianist interrupt the incessant, buzzing figurations. The occasional jabs of dynamic surges add to the scornfulness of this movement, and its unprecedented shortness (the whole movement lasts 2 minutes), combined with an abrupt *fortissimo* at the end, were surely designed to stir and dumbfound the audience. Still, the concise and monolithic form of the *Scherzo* also contributed to its attractiveness and success with the public—the *Scherzo* was often repeated during the concerts or played as an encore (with the exception of the premiere, when a surprised Prokofiev was not ready to succumb once again to its technical challenges). The ironic interplay of musical elements is partially obscured by the vitality and relative simplicity of the rhythmic structure. Nevertheless, as shown in the above analysis, Prokofiev employed in this very short and deceptively simple *Scherzo* a wealth of musical traditions and ideas.

CHAPTER 7

INTERMEZZO. STUDY IN GROTESQUE

In the literature on the Second Piano Concerto, the third movement has provoked the most vivid descriptions, which seem to converge on one feature: grotesquerie. Even though Prokofiev objected to using this term when discussing his music, the exaggerated and fantastic soundscape of the *Intermezzo* fits the definition of grotesque much better than that of "mockery," which Prokofiev had suggested. Several aspects of the general meaning of "grotesque"—distorted and unnatural shape, fantastical and ludicrously odd themes—can be found in the unusually colorful imagery provoked by this movement, with an emphasis slanted toward the terrifying and horrible. David Nice talks about "the soloist nimbly cavorting between the bass-heavy monsters of the lumbering parade" (2003, 95); Jaffe describes "grotesque, even monstrous sounding music" (2008, 35); most famously, to Sviatoslav Richter this movement brings thoughts of "a dragon devouring its children" (Steinberg 1998, 346). These descriptions seem to conform to Esti Sheinberg's view on the grotesque in music: "The grotesque ... conveys a distorted reality of a hyperbolic nature. A grotesque object is never 'comic' but rather 'ludicrous;' never just 'unpleasant', but rather 'repellent' or 'horrifying'" (Sheinberg 2001, 210).

Young Prokofiev was familiar with grotesque themes, which were common in Russian literature and art at the beginning of the twentieth century. Esti Sheinberg asserts:

> The mixture of the macabre, sensual and satirical that makes up the grotesque is so characteristic of Russian literature that it is almost hard to think about a Russian literary work that is devoid of this trait. The grotesque is a main device in Gogol's *The Government Inspector* (1836) and in his *Dead Souls* (1835-52); it is a dominant factor in Dostoyevsky's works, starting from *Poor Folk* and *The Double*, both written in 1846, through *The Village of Stepanchikovo* (1859) and

> *The Idiot* (1868-69) up to *The Possessed* (1872) and *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879-90). (2001, 282)

Besides his exposure to the literary grotesque, Prokofiev was familiar with various theatrical endeavors that used the grotesque as an expressive tool. According to Michael V. Pisani he even staged with his colleagues productions of *kapustniki,* "a distinctly Slavic version of grotesque comedy" based on improvised satirical skits (Pisani 1997, 4). Pisani believes that Prokofiev's satirical preferences and "unusual pleasure" in the farcical stem from his involvement in *kapustniki*. The popularity of *kapustniki* can be attested to by the participation of the finest actors and such directors as Konstantin Stanislavsky (1863–1938) and Vsevolod Meyerhold (1874–1940).

Meyerhold, a prominent proponent of grotesque theater who became an important figure in Prokofiev's later operatic undertakings, was already active in St. Petersburg, first in the *Aleksandrinski* and later in the *Mariinski Theatre*. When in 1916 Prokofiev played for Meyerhold his first mature and completed opera, *The Gambler* (based on Dostoyevsky), the director exclaimed: "You cannot know yourself what you have created; it will overturn the entire art of opera" (Prokofiev 2008, 141). The artistic kinship between the composer and the director may have stemmed from their similar views on the role of irony and the grotesque in life and art. In the following passage, the description of Meyerhold's esthetic aims fits those of young Prokofiev's with an uncanny resemblance:

> For Meyerhold, the grotesque was the most dynamic means at the disposal of theatre artists for giving expression to the *joie de vivre* which is all too often missing from man's daily life. And it must be understood that for Meyerhold the joy of living was to be found not so much in the simple pleasures and quiet contentedness as in the fireworks of life's contrasts, conflicts and dissonances. Furthermore, the grotesque was not to be construed simply as a manifestation of skepticism or ironic detachment; rather, it was for him the artist's involvement in a

> search for meanings...[For Meyerhold, the theatre was] a place for confronting the audience, through conventionalized means peculiar to the theatre, with a synthesized distillation of life's extremities in conflict with one another. (Symons 1971, 67 quoted in Pisani 1997, 499)

Prokofiev's "joy of living" and his appreciation of "life's contrasts, conflicts and dissonances" found manifestation not only in most of his piano works of the conservatory years, but also in descriptions of his daily activities and pursuits left in the *Diaries*.

Prokofiev might have been right to object to the overuse of the term "grotesque" in relation to his music. Similar to Prokofiev's position, Peter Fingesten warns against using this term too freely in the visual arts: "If the form alone is so exaggerated, distorted, or violent as to call for the descriptive term 'grotesque,' but the subject is not, or, if the subject is grotesque, but the form is not related to it (academic, for instance), then we are not dealing, in the opinion of this writer, with fully realized works of art of this symbolic genre, but with almost or quasi-grotesques" (Fingesten 1984, 420). I propose that in consideration of the grotesque form of the *Intermezzo* we need to consider an ironic use of its title, as well as its odd position within the form of a piano concerto.

The precedent for using an *Intermezzo* movement within a concerto form was established by Schumann in his Piano Concerto in A minor. However, Schumann's *Intermezzo* meets the tempo expectations of the concerto's middle movement (*Andantino*, between two *Allegro* movements), even though it is not the usual slow middle movement, which is probably why Schumann chose for it a different title. Its character remains unassuming and serves as an interjection between the more substantial outer movements. The middle movement of Rachmaninov's Third Piano Concerto, a lush *Adagio*, is also

named *Intermezzo*.[9] Like Schumann's *Intermezzo*, it is sandwiched between two imposing and contrasting fast movements, justifying its title. In the case of Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto, the *Intermezzo* appears instead of a slow movement, whose absence has confused both listeners and performers. Interestingly, many pianists and conductors have ignored the original tempo marking, *Allegro moderato*, and imposed an expected slower tempo, closer to that of a slow movement. This trend, however, seems to have ended with the most recent performances of Evgeny Kissin and Yundi Li (historically, the slowest reading was Demidenko's 8' 35" compared with 5' 40" of Yundi Li). The substantial size of the third movement as well as its grandiose pathos contradict an anticipated character of a conventional *intermezzo,* established in the piano literature not only by the two concertos mentioned above, but above all by Brahms's intimate pieces. Several layers of semantically incongruous musical topics presented in the course of the movement further amplify the formal incongruity of the third movement.

Esti Sheinberg points to semantic ambiguity resulting from the coexistence of incongruous layers as the basis of all types of musical irony, including the grotesque:

> Irony in its broadest sense, both as a tool for satirical purpose and as an expression of the unresolvable, could be regarded as a structural prototype for all other modes of ambiguity... Embodied in a specific case, where the horrifying and the ludicrous are interwoven into one unit of unresolvable contradiction, the grotesque displays irony mainly in its second function. (2001, 28)

Right at the beginning of the movement, Prokofiev establishes a matrix of associations between death, the unnatural and the horrifying—all of which are elements of the grotesque style. The opening bars introduce a sinister march, in orchestration

[9] It is not clear whether Prokofiev was familiar with Rachmaninov's Third Concerto: it was premiered in Moscow on April 17, 1910 but to my knowledge not performed in St. Petersburg before 1913 (the planned premiere in January of 1910 was canceled because the parts did not arrive on time from New York).

emphasizing low-range instruments, creating a striking effect after the breezy *Scherzo* (Figure 7.1). The avoidance of higher instruments and the coupling of low brass with the timpani yield a similar effect to that of Liszt's *Totentanz*.

Leonid Sabaneev pointed out in 1936 that while there were many followers of Liszt in Europe, they assimilated only elements of Liszt's legacy: "Liszt, having no big artistic following in Europe, where his most essential features were unrecognized, found a prompt and ardent response in Russia...The Russian National School, which originated with Glinka, the 'Father of Russian Music' and was continued through the Kutchka to Scriabin, was entirely the offspring of Liszt's demoniac genius" (689). To Sabanayev, the predominant feature of Liszt's style ignored in Europe but embraced in Russia was the "organic exoticism" and "demonism" of his music. Tellingly, Francis Poulenc proclaimed Prokofiev the "Russian Liszt," acknowledging his pianistic virtuosity and expanding dynamic range of the instrument (Fiess, 1994). As in the *Andantino*, Prokofiev evokes a character of the *Dies Irae* without direct quotation by supplying an instrumentation characteristic of a "dance of death"—low-register brass and percussion (Nikolai Rimski-Korsakov, a master orchestrator and Prokofiev's teacher described low range trombones as dark and threatening). Prokofiev evokes the horrifying atmosphere not only by instrumentation but also unnaturally wide leaps in strings and bassoons, and "trembling" trills. Wide leaps form a direct opposition to a singing topic in one semiotic unit: the natural expression of a singing line is opposed to the unnatural, non-human characteristic of leaps. The "inhuman" quality leads to associations with the fantastic world of monsters and dragons, which found their way into descriptive passages about this movement.



Figure 7.1. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Intermezzo.* Orchestral introduction.

Purposely or not, Richter's evocation of a dragon devouring its young directs us to a famous painting by Francisco de Goya: "Saturno devorando a su hijo" (Saturn devouring its child), hailed by Peter Fingesten as one of the most grotesque paintings in the history of art (Figure 7.2):

> Rarely has the feeling of the horrible been expressed in a more convincing manner. From a dark, mysterious background emerges a gigantic monster with bent knees, hair flying, eyes bulging hysterically, mouth wide open, swallowing the bloody arm of his daughter whose head he has already bitten off. His large hands lift the dead child by her chest, squeezing out the last spark of life from her limp body. This painting shocks and violates our sensibilities because of the extreme situation of a father eating his own daughter. The looseness of the form, distortion of the monster's arms, thighs, and legs, dark color scheme, open texture, and strong composition combine to form an integrated masterpiece of the grotesque genre. (Fingesten 1984, 422)



Figure 7.2. F. de Goya: "Saturno devorando a su hijo" c. 1819–1823. Oil mural transferred to canvas, Museo del Prado, Madrid.

Admittedly, there is no equivalency of expressiveness between visual arts and music; however, the verbal description of features signifying the grotesque in this painting can be applied to grotesquery in music: “looseness of form,” “distortion,” “open texture,” “strong composition,” even a “dark color scheme” are all present in Prokofiev's *Intermezzo*. The next paragraphs will examine how Prokofiev used various musical

elements in relation to the grotesque style.

Prokofiev, describing the formal plan of this movement in his *Diaries*, explained:

> The idea of it is that the music moves from G minor to somewhere else and arrives at the trio, while the reprise returns to G minor at the same time as most of the melodic ideas, both their general shape and their treatment, go from high to low pitch and from forte to piano, whereas at the beginning of the movement the general tendency is from low to high and from piano to forte. (2006, 373)

Prokofiev's preference for symmetry has already been demonstrated to a certain degree in the *Scherzo*, as well as in the opening movement (where motive x appeared at the beginning, the end, and right at the center). Far from the elaborated constructions of Bartók or Messiaen, Prokofiev's symmetrical idea may have more in common with a mirror-like doubling of musical characters and themes in Rimski-Korsakov's music (Morrison 2001, 261). Despite the encompassing large symmetry, the form of the *Intermezzo* movement seems loose and whimsical. Motivic repetition permeates the entire movement. March sections are interspersed with fantastical piano variations spun over a sparse orchestral accompaniment based on four-note motives derived from the "giant steps" of the introduction.

After establishing the terrifying character at the beginning of the movement, Prokofiev resorts to mockery. The muted trumpets try to mimic the effect of the trombones but produce only distorted and inadequate sound. The following clarinet scales do not bring any sense of relief; rather, they evoke a sense of anxious anticipation. An *ostinato* of wide leaps in the low strings and bassoons is a constant reminder of the initial trauma. The use of leaps, staccato, pizzicato and short motives interjected with rests creates an unsettling landscape, which could be interpreted as jocular if not for the heaviness of orchestration and extreme fragmentation of the piano's texture. The blurred

distinction between laughter and horror adds to the overall unease and lies right at the basis of grotesque style. “The grotesque is an unresolvable ironic utterance, a hybrid that combines the ludicrous with the horrifying” (Sheinberg 2001, 207). Mockery of death is followed by a mockery of rural happiness, a parodistic version of Schumann's ”Vogel Als Prophet” (Figures 7.3 and 7.4)[10]:



Figure 7.3. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Intermezzo*. Entrance of the piano part.



Figure 7.4. R. Schumann: “Vogel als Prophet” from *Waldszenen*, Op. 82 (Breitkopf & Härtel [Leipzig], 1879-1912. Public domain)

10 Zielinski thinks that it was Poulenc who first noticed resemblance between Schumann's piece and this section of *Intermezzo* (1959, 56).

Where Schumann creates a calm, pleasant and somewhat melancholy scene, Prokofiev's wild figurations hint at some fantastical hopping dance, where birds may be present only in a form of distorted masks. Short glissando-like figures, an exaggerated version of Mozart's triple appoggiaturas, were frequently used in fantastical pieces of the era, from Rimski-Korsakov's operas to Mussorgsky's *Night on Bald Mountain*. The hopping glissandos lead to a dysphoric march, whose flow is intercepted by up-swinging, diatonic, glissando-like scales and downward, empty-sounding arpeggios. Wide leaps saturate the piano part until the march reaches its anti-climax; an obsessive repetitiveness of both piano and orchestral parts create a static plateau, devoid of direction. Interestingly, Sheinberg sees repetitiveness as another feature of the grotesque style dealing with sanity and insanity: "the repetitive character of the dancing, often supplemented by repetitive rhythmical patterns as well, can point to obsessive behavior" (2001, 220). The harmonic plan of this section is obscured by a succession of unresolved seventh chords and empty octaves; the upward direction of the glissandos is contradicted by the general downward motion of repeated phrases. The sudden appearance of the dominant G major is quickly riposted by a succession of descending chords, invalidating any euphoric content usually associated with climactic moments. The following transitional episode in any other context would be considered full of anxious resignation—in the distorted reality of the *Intermezzo* it sounds blissfully relaxed.

The next variation employs a stream of triplet figures in 12/8 meter, which Raymond Monelle links to a horse topic (2000, 54). However, Prokofiev strips this topic of the heroic and noble value usually associated with it. Monelle, in his extensive description of various manifestations of horse topics, takes into account that nineteenth-

century music occasionally features the equestrian rhythm "connected with a somber and ominous coloring" (2000, 61), as in Brahms's "Wehe, so willst du mich wieder," Op.32 no.5, and Mussorgsky's "Field Marshal," the last of the *Songs and Dances of Death*. The horse topic associated with death can also appear in a grotesque form, as in Berlioz's *Symphonie fantastique*. To Monelle, such a dysphoric form of horse topic is typically associated with the witches' sabbath and as such it was used by Wagner in *Die Walküre*, Liszt's "Wilde Jagd," and Mendelssohn's cantata *Die erste Walpurgsnacht* (2000, 62).

The horse topic makes two appearances in the *Intermezzo*, in a mirroring symmetry. First it is played softly and accompanied by swinging motives in the left hand; if the original horse topic is equated with masculinity, this version has a more feminine, consoling feel. The second appearance of the horse topic is presented by the solo piano, played with a dry, loud staccato and accompanied by triple grace-note figures in the left-hand part. These glides, or mini-glissandos, since the time of Mozart, have been associated with tremors and the supernatural. In Mozart's Piano Concerto in D minor, Kv. 466, they appear in the orchestral introduction (Figure 7.5); Charles Rosen labels them "menacing" and credits them, along with the syncopations, as giving "a powerful impression of foreboding" (Rosen 1997, 233). The motive appears in the last act of *Don Giovanni*, when it announces a frightening entrance of the Commendatore (Figure 7.6). Later, Liszt used it in his *Mephisto Waltz* No.1 (Figure 7.7), "Wilde Jagd" (5-note version), and *Totentanz*. Berlioz saturated the last movement of his *Symphonie fantastique* with all sorts of similar motives. Wagner used a similar motive in his *Siegfried*, in a scene with the dragon Fafner to depict "the heavy step of the giants" (Monelle 2000, 43).



Figure 7.5. W. A. Mozart: Piano Concerto in D minor, Kv. 466. I *Allegro.* (Breitkopf & Härtel [Leipzig] 1878. Public domain)



Figure 7.6. W.A. Mozart: *Don Giovanni*. *Finale* (G. Schirmer [New York], 1900. Public domain)



Figure 7.7. F. Liszt: *Mephisto Waltz* No. 1, S. 514 (Edition Peters [Leipzig] 1913-17. Public domain)

Transplanted to the fertile ground of Russian fantastic opera, the gliding appoggiaturas were used by virtually all composers of the "Mighty Five" (e.g. in Mussorgsky's *Night on a Bald Mountain*, Figure 7.8). Prokofiev used these gestural motives in the most apparent way in his *Suggestions diabolique* (Figure 7.9). In the *Intermezzo*, they add another dimension to an already fantastical landscape.



Figure 7.8. M. Mussorgsky: Night on a Bald Mountain, rev. by N. Rimski-Korsakov (W. Bessel & Cie [St. Petersburg] ca. 1887. Public domain)



Figure 7.9. S. Prokofiev: *Suggestions diabolique,* Op. 4 No. 4 (Dover Publications 2000)

In the trio Prokofiev bows to the oriental streak in Russian music. Orientalism was an essential element in Russian literature and music of the nineteenth century, and its popularity peaked during the rule of Alexander II (1818-1881); the interest in Islam and the East coincided with Russian imperial conquests in the Caucasus. When Diaghilev introduced Russian music to European audiences through productions of the *Ballet Russes*, he relied heavily on orient-inspired pieces. His first production featured Mussorgsky's *Khovanshchina*, Borodin's *Polovtsian Dances* and Rimski-Korsakov's *Scheherazade*. As a result, orientalism and "Russianness" fused together in the popular culture. Upon first hearing Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto, Diaghilev "was rapturous" and very enthusiastic about Prokofiev's tendency towards a nationalist style. Their first meeting in London in 1914 resulted in Prokofiev's subsequent engagement with Diaghilev's ballet company; there was even talk of transforming the Concerto into a ballet, but eventually a new commission replaced this idea.

Diaghilev was very taken by the Russian style of the *Finale*, but he must have appreciated the orientalism of the middle section of the *Intermezzo* as well. Francis Maes points out that the oriental style in music is not limited to the use of authentic Eastern melodies, but more importantly, uses specific musical codes representing either "Dionysian intoxication" or "hedonistic sensuality" (2002, 82). An example of the first type would be Balakirev's *Islamey* with its obsessive rhythms, climactic effects and accelerating tempi. The orchestral scores often call for the use of a Turkish drum, the tambourine, or other percussive instruments evoking an "Eastern" sound. Hedonistic sensuality, which Maes equates with "sensual longing," is reflected musically by rhythmical and metric irregularity, augmented and diminished intervals, melodic lines

revolving around frequently recurring notes, and extensive ornamentation (Maes 2002, 82). Another feature of the sensual type of oriental style is chromatic alterations of the 5th and 6th scale-degrees. This very particular melodic pattern 5—#5—6—6b—5 was so common among the composers of the Mighty Five (*Kutchka*) that Maria Frolova-Walker indicated it as the "*Kutchka* calling-card" and named it the "*Kutchka* pattern" (Frolova-Walker 2008, 142). Taruskin, the most prominent scholar of the Russian style, calls this pattern "the essential *nega* undulation," where *nega* is an old Russian term for sexual pleasure (1992, 266). Certainly *neg*a or the "*Kutchka* pattern" is not limited to the Mighty Five. Balakirev criticized Tchaikovsky for using the oriental *nega* in *Romeo and Juliet* (1869; revised 1870, 1880) accusing the composer of turning the European lovers into Persians. The "frank sensual iconicity" of the love themes from *Romeo and Juliet* was traditionally attributed to "the throbbing, panting" English horn line, but Taruskin believes that "the themes evoke *nega* just as surely by means of the strongly marked chromatic pass between the fifth and sixth degrees" (1997, 182).

At first, Prokofiev evokes the oriental character by several of the techniques described by Maes. The melody oscillates between A, G and G# (the augmented 4th in D minor: the key of the middle section). The dotted rhythms coupled with similar chromaticism were consistently used by Russian composers to reflect sensual iconicity, as in Rachmaninov's "Ne poy, krasavitsa,*"* Op. 4 No. 4, Borodin's *Prince Igor* and *In Central Asia*, and Glinka's *Ruslan and Ludmila*, to name just a few. At the turning point of the entire movement, right where the ascending motion reverses its tide and starts a gradual descent to the final pizzicatos at the lowest register, Prokofiev employs a text-book version of *nega* (Figure 7.11).


71
1. Fl.
2.
Ob.
Cl. in La
Fag.
P dolce, un poco scherzando
pp
1. Solo
Cor in Fa
p
Tb-no.
T. mil.
Perc
Ossia
gliss.
etc.
Solo Pfte.
71
con sord.
Sul G
I. Vl.
II.
Vle.
Vc.
Cb.
p un poco espr.



Figure 7.11. S. Prokofiev. Second Piano Concerto. *Intermezzo*. Trio. *Nega* (Kutchka pattern), presented by 1st Flutes and 1st Violins (R. 71).

The theme is played by flutes, bassoons and violins, and accompanied by tambourines (the most iconic choice to carry a melody would be an English horn, but it was not included in the limited instrumentation of the Second Concerto). Throughout the trio, the piano assumes a role of a harp (another instrument iconic in depictions of the orient but missing in this orchestration), playing arpeggios and glissandos. As at the beginning of

the trio, these arpeggios have an upward direction, conforming to the general direction of the formal ascension described by Prokofiev, after the turning point (R. 71), they change direction to downward, alternating between white- and black-key glissandos. The heroic reappearance of the horse topic in a form of a piano solo marks the end of the trio section and leads to a triumphant return of the march.

The reprise of the first part leads to a cataclysmic climax, appropriately resembling the ruckus of several Ottoman orchestras playing simultaneously. The themes of the introduction come back with even bigger force, fuller orchestration, and accompanied by choral cascades in the piano part. This marks the most dissonant and discordant moment of the entire concerto. From there, descending chromatic scales in a chordal setting lead to a steep decrescendo to a low G. The quiet ending, the most sparse of the entire movement and incongruous with the preceding monstrosity, seems to indicate that what was heard before was just a fairy tale.

The analysis of the *Intermezzo* has shown how Prokofiev masterfully juggled several different aspects of the grotesque style. Horrifying and mocking elements are interspersed, and exaggeration permeates the formal structure and melodic contours. This fantastic realm, manifested by unnaturalness and abnormal and unexpected sonorities, is complemented by the oriental sensuality of the trio, both rooted in the fantastic tradition of Russian opera.

CHAPTER 8

FINALE: STUDY IN THE RUSSIAN CHARACTER

The *Finale* of the Second Piano Concerto is the most traditional of the four movements in both form and content. Even though the modified sonata-allegro form shows its intricacies—a telescopic reprise and a piano cadenza filling most of a development section—it tries to please the audience with a beautiful Russian theme dominating the character and delivery of this final movement. It has been described as a streak of genius to delay the presentation of this theme until the last movement (Nice 2003, 94). Prokofiev surely anticipated that the striking novelty of the first three movements would create an uproar, and he might have wanted to finish the concerto with a more traditional *finale* to ensure its critical acclaim. Traditionally, the *Finale* employs two themes, contrasting not only musically, but also in their topical significance. The first theme belongs to a toccata line of Prokofiev's creativity, as exemplified in the earlier Toccata, Op. 11, and the *Scherzo* of this Concerto. The second theme is a Russian lullaby, one of the most intimate themes in the composer's output. The toccata style is linked with virtuosity and public display. The extreme angularity and dryness of the first theme's leaps brings in associations with the inhuman and automatic. On the other hand, a lullaby is a manifestation of the most caring and intimate aspects of human life. Hence, the contrast relies not only on the juxtaposition of different types of movement and dynamism, but more importantly, on the contradiction between mechanistic and human, cool and warmth, detachment and involvement, emptiness and fulfillment.

Nestyev reads in the unusual leaps of the main theme a "suggestion of untamed

primordial forces" (1961, 74). Once the texture is stripped of these leaps, however, it reveals a simple chromatic melody oscillating around the raised fourth, C#. It is, in fact, the same undulating pattern that Prokofiev used in the oriental trio of the *Intermezzo*: the Kutchka pattern, or *nega*. There, employed in accordance with its traditional topos, it underlined the sensual and seductive character of the melody. Here, liberated with a parodistic laughter, it is a part of a futuristic and utterly non-human automaton. Prokofiev showed a predilection for a similar character in many other pieces, especially in his Toccata, Op. 11, and Sonata No. 2, Op. 14 (Boris Berman mentions musical automatons when describing the "multipersonalities" of the Second Piano Sonata [2008, 57]).

I suggest that the squareness of the overlapping jumps as a pianist experiences them can be seen as a reflection of the squareness of automata gestures.

The fascination with *automata* was initially centered on its ability to mimic human features, movement or skills. Offenbach's opera *Tales of Hoffman* features a singing automata, Olympia—a contradiction in itself: "Singing (like speaking) plays strongly against the implications of puppetry and mechanism that haunt instrumental performance...we oppose the idea that the human voice could be artificial much more vigorously than we reject instrumental music as potentially mechanical in origin" (Abbate 1999, 483). Composers of the twentieth century, in reverse, were stripping their music of human-like qualities in an ironic attempt to distance themselves from romanticism. The first theme of the *Finale* in its utmost un-singable quality associates with this trend. Coincidentally, the year 1913 brought about a "paradoxical synthesis of enchantment and mechanism" in Ravel's works (Abbate 1999, 495). "Setting automata in motion" as an ironic gesture appeared also in Eric Satie's "Bottle-Imps, Puppets, Little

Wooden Men and Bronze Statues," Maitre Pierre's Punch and Judy figures in de Falla, as well as the dolls in Stravinsky's *Petrushka*. Features of "automatism" can be also observed in works that have no text, title, or narrative aligning them with machines or toys (Abbate 1999, 496). Prokofiev's later *Pas d'acier* (1925), which he composed soon after revision of the Second Piano Concerto, much more deliberately deals with sounds of machines in its depiction of a steel factory.

Prokofiev already experimented with similarly mechanical textures in his Toccata, Op. 11, composed in 1912 and premiered in 1916. As in the Toccata, the texture of the first theme in the *Finale* is split between two hands interjecting each other. Simultaneous jumps result in a truly acrobatic experience, which may be successful only on a subliminal, or fully automated level (Figure 8.1). The virtuosity of this theme is undeniable, and appears even more fiendish when observed in performance. The visual aspects of virtuosity are remarkably important: "Virtuosity must be public, visible, in order to earn the pianist the status of a seer with unique abilities" (Klein 2005, 66). For many years Prokofiev remained the only performer of the Second Concerto. He assumed the role of a super-pianist, the only one who could decipher the concerto's physical challenges, fitting Klein's description of virtuosity "aligned with interpretative power, inscribing the score with the quality of a secret message" (2005, 65). Through transcending physical constraints, virtuosity signifies transcendence and a breaking of boundaries.



Figure 8.1. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Finale*. Entrance of the first theme.

While the unusual leaps of the first theme hardly have a precedent in nineteenth-century piano music, the idea of transcending physical boundaries was an integral undercurrent in romantic music. Prokofiev's maturation as a composer was informed by the emergence of the Russian piano school at the turn of the twentieth century. Seen as a

direct upshot of the Lisztian tradition, the Russian school dominated the pianistic scene in the first half of the twentieth century not only in Russia but also worldwide. While Liszt's technical advances had a profound influence over many composers, a specific mix of Liszt-infused compositional teaching and perfectionist conservatory piano training resulted in an unprecedented wealth of virtuosic Russian piano music. Liszt was instrumental in the creation of both the Moscow and St. Petersburg Conservatories by recommending his pupils and other pianists for teaching positions, and by the influence his pianism had over Nikolay and Anton Rubinstein (Zenkin, 2001). His music was an essential and mandatory part of the Conservatory's training. Prokofiev studied Liszt's B minor Sonata and his transcriptions right at the time of composing the Second Concerto. Many prominent pianist-composers in Russia were followers of the Liszt tradition, including Aleksander Scriabin and most prominently Sergei Rachmaninov (Zenkin 2001, 106). The widely circulated opinion about Prokofiev's disdain for Rachmaninov's music is untrue. Prokofiev admired many works by Rachmaninov, even his ultra-romantic Second Piano Concerto. In April 1913 he praised Rachmaninov's First Concerto as well:

> What a glorious work Rachmaninov's First Concerto is (the first movement). Even allowing for the thinness of the musical material and a certain immaturity, how lovely is its representation of sincerity, tenderness and a general feeling of delight. On top of that its pianism is beyond reproach and it is utterly free of routine passages for the soloist. (Prokofiev 2006, 374)

Rachmaninov's innovative pianistic textures had a more profound effect on Prokofiev than those of the old master, Liszt. Still, Prokofiev never imitated, but rather transcended the sources of his inspiration. Hence, the virtuosity of the Second Piano Concerto, while firmly grounded in pianistic traditions, aims at dethroning Rachmaninov as the

embodiment of transcendent virtuosity in Russia, and establishing young Prokofiev in its stead.

If the first theme is a parodistic contradiction of the oriental sensualism of the *Intermezzo*, the following quotation from the *Scherzo*, obsessively repetitive, sounds threatening and uncanny (compare Figure 8.2 and Figure 6.8). This effect is substantiated by a suffocating closeness of chromatic figures and a change in the orchestral coloring: light pizzicatos in the strings give way to *arco* playing, accompanied by tuba, a reminiscence of the *Intermezzo*'s dragons and the *Andantino*'s uncanny return of motive x.

The contrast between the first theme and the orchestral introduction to the second theme could not be more striking. The unpredictability of jumps, chromaticism, harmonic ambiguity, and sharpness of articulation are juxtaposed with uneventful, simple diatonic phrases (with the exception of the raised 5th), firmly based in D minor, repeated four times without the slightest embellishment. The theme is presented by the solo piano, a tellingly intimate setting, congruous with the presented topic: a lullaby (Figure 8.3).

The theme's strikingly Russian character (to the ears of a non-Russian) gives strong credence to the perseverance of Balakirev's national idiom in the music of the twentieth century. This idiom stems from Mily Balakirev's edition of national tunes, collected along the Volga river in the 1860s. Taruskin credits Balakirev with creating the style

> …instantly recognizable to us today as generically "Russian," thanks to its thorough assimilation into the later compositional practice not only of Balakirev himself but that of his followers Rimski-Korsakov, Mussorgsky, and Borodin, not to mention such postkutchkist epigones as Glazunov, Lyadov and Lyapunov. (Taruskin 1997, 133)



Figure 8.2. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Finale* (R. 94-95, 97).



Figure 8.3. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Finale*. Second theme.

The most striking feature of Balakirev's harmonizations is an avoidance of dominant harmonies, which at the time were dominating Western-European music. Balakirev also extended the repertoire of folk genres. Initially, Glinka and his followers used predominantly one type of a tune: the *protyazhnaya.* The melancholy character of these songs and their minor mode came to symbolize "the essence of Russian creativity and the 'Russian soul' itself" (Frolova-Walker 2008, 30). The folk tunes used by Glinka in the first Russian opera *A Life for the Tsar* were a product of their assimilation into urban culture. Taruskin's list of traits for this "urban *style russe"* converges with the style of the lullaby used by Prokofiev in 1913: a predominance of duple or compound-duple time, cadential terminations by falling fourths or fifths, and the "mutable mode," an interplay of major and minor modes. To Glinka, the cadential falling fourths and fifths were an embodiment of "the soul of Russian music" (Taruskin 1997, 29); Prokofiev in his Russian theme does not limit their use to cadences, but bases the entire opening phrase on them.

After the extensive presentation of this melancholy theme by the solo piano, the orchestra takes over the melody, while the piano delivers ever-growing figurations

leading eventually to a powerful and fulfilling climax. A new toccata segment in D minor marks the beginning of the development section. Even though motivically it presents new material, the character, as well as the reliance on whole and half tones, link this new section to the first theme. However, while most of the orchestra and subsequently the piano carry on the toccata theme, the oboes and bassoons sneak in the motives of the second theme. As the piano's toccata becomes more insistent in the *tempestoso* section, the second theme gains a stronger voice as well—now presented by a horn. As though in retreat, the toccata drifts away, minimalizing its driving energy gradually, until all that is left is a pulsating repetition of the note D (R. 116). Then, in an unexpected and ominous outcry, the orchestra presents an E-flat minor chord, the minor Neapolitan, resolving on a unison D. Both the tremolos and Neapolitans are unmistakable signs of *ombra,* a topic signifying a threat of the unknown. Here it serves as a prophetic call for the return of the uncanny section from the exposition. The uncanny motives previously led to the second theme. This time, however, the solo piano hesitantly and heavily climbs through the cadenza until it reaches a high C-sharp (the Dominant in the newly established F-sharp minor tonality, but also a leading tone in D). From there, as if finding the Dominant triggered a rediscovery of its familiar virtuosic voice, through a stream of arpeggios and supporting chordal harmonies alternating between D minor and F-sharp minor, the piano leads to a presentation of an embellished version of the first theme in F-sharp minor (rather than the expected G minor). The entrance of the orchestra with the second theme suddenly slides the tonality to A minor. Through the rest of the development the piano presents the first theme in an increasingly disintegrated form, while the orchestra continues its presentation of the second theme in a strong and complete shape. Eventually

the piano is left alone, playing softly the second theme's motives until those also disintegrate into a string of repetitions and die away.

The recapitulation, as telescopic as the recapitulation of the first movement, starts with the same material as the exposition, but the first theme appears in a new form. Instead of the melody evoking *nega*, there is a simple rising progression first based on the interval of a tenth, then a ninth. It appears that the disintegration of the second theme, which occurred in the development under the expressive honesty of the second theme, has stripped the first theme of its parodistic tendency. In the recapitulation the first theme's purely mechanistic virtuosity seems even more evident as it looses its melodic contour. The coda utilizes other virtuosic elements of the movement, like the toccata section from the development. The very last seconds of the movement provoked much uproar during the premiere thanks to the highly dissonant cluster of G minor and A major chords, played simultaneously (Figure 8.4). Remembering Charles Rosen's insightful remarks, "It is not the unfamiliarity or strangeness of a composer's manner that is a bar to understanding, but rather the disappearance of the familiar" (Rosen 1994), we redirect our attention to the very telling absence of the last pages: there is not a single dominant chord. Instead, Prokofiev relies on minor Neapolitan harmonies and the secondary dominant of A major. The very last sustained harmony is that of a subdominant chord without a third, with a strong emphasis on the fifth–G, which nullifies any traditionally expected effect of a final resolution at the end (Figure 8.5).

Deborah Stein notices and describes the expansion of the subdominant in late nineteenth-century music as one of the ways of creating more complex musical structures:

> The nature of the plagal axis is the posing of a less forceful and more ambiguous tonal opposition which requires a unique resolution. The tonal opposition in the plagal axis is different from that of its tonic-dominant counterpart; the dissonance arising from the ambiguity of the plagal domain creates a different sense of progression and resolution…By itself it creates a weaker tonal structure whose tonal definition is inherently unclear. (1983, 175)

Taruskin describes an avoidance of dominant harmonies as one of the defining features of the Russian style, established by Balakirev's harmonization practices in opposition to the dominant-oriented tradition of the Germanic school in Western Europe. Throughout the Second Piano Concerto, Prokofiev showed allegiance to this traditional Russian harmonic language. Dominant harmonies rarely underline the structural development of this piece. Avoiding a strong cadence at the end of his monumental work presents an explicit and intended jab at the academic tradition: "The coda in the *Finale* is very convincing and appropriate, but I don't expect it will please those who take pleasure in decoding this Concerto" (Prokofiev 2006, 349). If the effect of puzzled bewilderment was the composer's intention, he succeeded: the brevity of the coda and an enigmatic, abrupt ending are certainly an appropriate finishing stroke, complementing a piece based on ambiguities and internal conflicts.

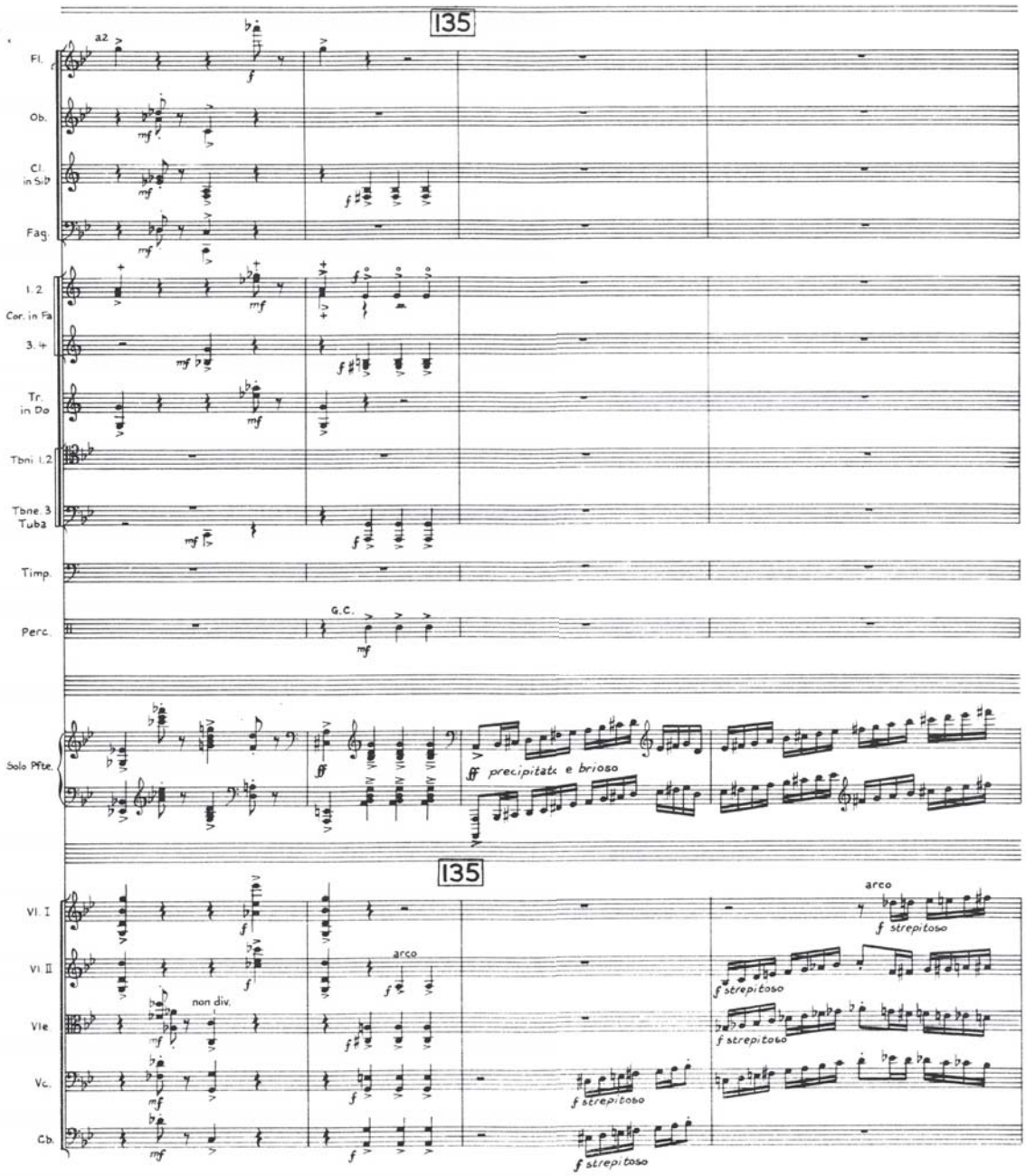


Figure 8.4. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Finale*. Cluster of G minor and A major chords



Figure 8.5. S. Prokofiev: Second Piano Concerto. *Finale*. Concluding passage.

CHAPTER 9

SUMMARY

Prokofiev composed his Second Piano Concerto soon after a successful premiere of his First Concerto. In his memoirs, Prokofiev stressed that the direct impulse for composing the Second Piano Concerto was his resolve to combat charges of empty showy brilliance and "footballishness" in the First Concerto (Prokofiev 1992, 243). Prokofiev's goal was to prove that he could compose works of a greater depth. To achieve this goal he resolved to use traditionally accepted techniques, rooted in the Romantic tradition. Young Prokofiev showed that his studies at the St. Petersburg Conservatory equipped him with solid stylistic and compositional skills and a thorough knowledge of the Romantic literature.

It is well known that Prokofiev openly and loudly opposed the Romantic style and its epigones within the Russian musical scene. He built his reputation as an *enfant terrible* through a series of compositions devoid of references to the Romantic expressive style. However, as a maturing composer, Prokofiev tried to reconcile some of the contradictory attitudes he felt toward his predecessors. During 1913 Prokofiev on many occasions expressed his admiration for Russian composers: Rimski-Korsakov, Tchaikovsky, and even Rachmaninov. The lyricism and broad expressive themes in the outer movements seem to be composed in continuation of the great Russian school of piano music.

But Prokofiev's "greater depth" shows also multi-dimensional aspects. On one hand he frequently resorts to layering of two or more musical topics or styles. On the

other hand, this layering, often involving incongruous elements, results in an ironic detachment from the Romantic idiom he just presented. Conflicting messages within the piece resulted in mixed critical response to the Second Piano Concerto. The Russian critics who were familiar with Prokofiev's other works praised the Concerto, seeing in it a significant advancement over his earlier pieces. To his contemporaries, the modernism of this Concerto was evident mostly in the chromatic and complex harmonic language, in the dissonant passages of the cadenza and *Intermezzo*, and in the clusters of the *Finale*. Prokofiev's friends, Karatygin and Asafyev, praised the innovativeness of the form and youthful vitality, among other features. However, both of them wrote their reviews upon multiple hearings and an analysis of the score. To the critics who heard the Concerto for the first time in performance, it appeared puzzling and even disturbing, which I ascribe to the ironic ambiguities of the score.

This analysis of the Second Concerto has revealed how Prokofiev juggled old traditions and a modern attitude. The Concerto's greater depth, particularly evident in the outer movements, came as result of utilizing musical topics traditionally associated with death and a somber character. Starting with setting the Concerto in a minor key, through a number of parallels to Chopin's and Tchaikovsky's music (among others), and utilizing conventions rooted in the Russian program and operatic music, Prokofiev saturated the score with elements having strong semiotic connotations in the musical tradition.

On the other end, Prokofiev exhibited a modern approach not only in the formal, harmonic and purely pianistic innovations, but also in an ironic detachment from the composition. In the nineteenth century, a composition's tone was commonly and justifiably linked to a composer's private circumstances. A musical composition was seen

as a product and reflection of the inner life of an artist, and Prokofiev's Second Piano Concerto was often contemplated in similar terms. As has been shown in the first part of this monograph, the tragic tone of the Concerto came as a result of the composer's resolution to avert criticism similar to his First Concerto. Private circumstances played no role in the shape and content of the piece. Apart from setting the historical record straight, this fact points to far more important implications. Prokofiev was one of many modern composers who stood up against Romantic ideals at the beginning of the 20th century. In his individual way Prokofiev used mockery, irony and the grotesque to distance himself from the Romantic tradition. Similar to a later neo-Classical trend, by using conventions rooted in Romanticism, he mocked not only a particular style but also attitudes and the worldview associated with it. Persistently through the piece Prokofiev used ironic statements created by a combination of semiotically ambiguous or contradictory elements. The minimal orchestration, one of the striking features of this otherwise monumental concerto, became one of the benchmarks of the neo-classical style in the twenties. Here, Prokofiev predates those developments, and by withdrawing the lush sound of the orchestra, he further undercuts the Romantic standard.

The Second Piano Concerto presents a musical illustration of the contradictory trends in the music of the early twentieth century in Russia. The unresolved contradictions between sincerity and mockery, modernism and traditionalism and a purely musical lack of balance between the piano and the orchestra marred the Concerto's popular success for many decades. Those same contradictions may be at the roots of the concerto's revival and growing popularity in today's pluralistic and contradictory world.

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APPENDICES

APPENDIX A

Timetable of the Composition Process Based on Prokofiev's *Diaries*

1912		
November 27	… I did some work on the Piano Concerto (No.2) and moved it forward	"I am busy with: our opera productions, my conducting, composition, my pursuit of targets 9 and 17, and Max. This is my life, my sphere of activity, where I feel at home, the domain of which I am king"
December 2	… I worked on the concerto, concentrating on the first movement's A minor theme. The first two bars are good, but I cannot go any further, When I got home, I read more of "The life of P. I. Tchaikovsky." I am entranced by this book, mainly because I find it such a tremendous spur to composition. I have begun the scherzo of the Concerto.	Prokofiev conducted a piano concerto for the first time. Learned Tchaikovsky's Piano Concerto. A "great triumph": Jurgenson sent his offer for the Second Sonata (200 rubles).
December 8	In the morning I practiced the Tchikinson (sic) Concerto and also worked on composing my own. The first movement promises to be excellent when I've finished it.	"This morning, while I was at work on Piano Concerto, Mama said, 'How horrible it sounds, just as if you had no ear at all!' My answer was to shut the door."
December 12	I slept late, then practiced the Tchaikovsky and also worked on the new sketches I had made for my concerto. In form and construction my Second Piano Concerto is going to be a consummate piece of work.	Conducted *Ivan the Terrible* at the Jubilee Concert.
December 24	… I managed to finish part of the *Intermezzo* of the Concerto.	Composed the *Scherzo* for 4 bassoons: "I began at eight o'clock and by half past midnight the *Scherzo* was complete and written out with all the finishing touches in place."
December 26	I worked quite well until lunchtime on the cadenza of the Concerto. It is complete in plan, but working out the details is taking a long time.	Just before waking I dreamed of Tchaikovsky; I was walking with him somewhere; he was so kind and gentle and made me feel so sad that I woke up in a very distressed state.
December 28	I settled down to the Concerto and worked slowly on the cadenza.	...production of *Onegin* moved me to tears...

December 29	The *scherzo* of the Concerto is as lively as one could wish, but the middle section is not yet up to scratch.	Ice-skating every night of the week.
December 30	Today I got up at midday and put the finishing touches to the piano part of the Concerto. When writing a concerto, if you conceive of it as a combination of piano and orchestra, the pianistic side of the solo part will always suffer. This has happened in about half the passages in my Concerto No.1 where the piano-orchestra combination is effective but not particularly interesting for the pianist to play. When composing the Second Concerto I paid a great deal of attention to the challenges of the solo part, but even so there are times when the composer-musician in me prevails over the composer-pianist, and I have not been able to avoid dull or, so to say routine, passages for the soloist.	I am very fond of Nina because of the inexhaustible fund of mischief buried within her.
1913		
January 23-February 3	Trip with Max to the Crimea.	Before the trip: preparing the *Queen of Spades* for the conducting concert. After: practicing Chopin's Sonata in B-flat.
February 12	Made some progress with the finale of the Concerto in the morning, composing the concluding material	In the evening Max and I went to the "Crooked mirror" and laughed ourselves silly.
February 17	…a prolonged spell of work on the Concerto. But as a composer it must be admitted that I work slowly—nowhere near rapidity of Tchaikovsky, who could turn out an entire opera scene in two days or thereabouts. One explanation of this could be Tchaikovsky's relative indifference to the harmonic aspect of his music: it takes much less time to write a melody than id does its harmonic accouterments. But I am always absorbed in the latter, with the result that after three hours' or so productive and uninterrupted work there can still be less than a page to show for it.	Conducted Weber's *Konzertstuck*. Went to Moscow to meet Koussevitsky, who promised to feature Prokofiev's Piano Concerto and other works in his concerts in the next season. Heard "a lovely programme": Rachmaninov's Isle of the Dead, Second Piano Concerto, and Scriabin's Extase ("I adored the last named, especially the place where the high moaning of the woodwinds is doubled by the horns down below, a marvelous passage").
March 3	Worked on the G minor Concerto in the morning. I am totally in thrall to it, but, my God, when will I ever finish it?	
March 6	I composed some of the third movement of the Concerto. This is undoubtedly a less	I have lost confidence in playing from memory, probably because I

	striking movement, but it has much good music in it and is impeccably put together.	never play anything without a score... I must take steps to deal with this disagreeable condition before it's too late. From now onwards I shall play by heart!
March 12	In the course of the morning I finished the sketches for the third movement. Everything has fitted together splendidly. I am happy.	Practiced Schumann's Sonata in F-sharp minor for Yesipova's class.
March 17	Worked intensively and productively on the *Finale* of the Concerto until half past two: a particularly successful passage has finally begun to flow in the development. The main thing is that up to now I have not been able to get the form of the second half of the *Finale* completely clear in my mind: this has been causing me a great deal of trouble and inhibited all desire to compose. But today the form manifested itself with great clarity down to its details. True, it does not conform to the best of old traditions, but in itself it is entirely logical and complete, and that is all that matters. I have great respect for the old forms, but I also have complete faith in my own instincts, and often give myself license to depart from convention.	
March 20	Had a good composing session on the *Finale* in the morning, a continuation of yesterday's.	
March 21	I worked right through until seven o'clock.... completing the coda of the *Finale* and the trio of the *Scherzo*. To my own great surprise the Concerto seems to be nearly finished: there remain the first movement cadenza (which I already sketched out in plan), and then all the gaps still needing to be stitched up, where I know what I want but not how to get it. This is primarily a matter of technique. I do not expect orchestration to take very long: I want to keep accompaniment simple and transparent. The coda in the *Finale* is very convincing and appropriate, but I don't expect it will please those who take pleasure in decoding this concerto. On the other hand, the *Scherzo*'s trio is as charming as can be.	What a glorious work Rachmaninov's First Concerto is (the first movement)! Even allowing for the thinness of the musical material and a certain immaturity, how lovely is its representation of sincerity, tenderness and a general feeling of delight. On top of that its pianism is beyond reproach and it is utterly free or routine passages for the soloist.
March 24	Worked on the composition of the Concerto (first movement cadenza) until four o'clock. As a bonus I also had a marvelous idea for the conclusion of the first movement, but I cannot work out the end of cadenza itself, that is to say how to connect the cadenza to the new idea. The join must be seamless, as this is a key point.	Bought the score of Tchaikovsky's Sixth Symphony, and reading it in the evening found myself utterly captivated by the stunning beauty of its emotional power. A thrilling work.
March 26	All morning and until half past three composed the Concerto. To be precise, all the material is now composed, but there are	I went to see Aslanov to talk about the summer concerts. I told him I should like to play the Second

	substantial sections where although thematic material and the harmony are in place, and the layout is there in principle, these sections are still represented physically by white, largely empty pages. To fill these pages with the details that will realize the conception I imagined while I was composing the material, is for me a task integral with the composition of the work seen as a whole. Today I filled in all the central episode of the first movement and worked with such intensity that I quite forgot to have any lunch.	Piano Concerto towards the end of the summer (before then I won't have learned it), and should also like to hear *Dreams*. He readily accepted both works.
March 29	Composition work on the Concerto. Had a completely new idea for the end of the first movement, which I think will be very good.	When I got home I looked with pleasure at the brilliantly successful caricature we had made for Ariadna. Then with equal enjoyment I read through my diary entries for the month and, pleased with life, went to bed.
April 1	Completed the first movement cadenza, all but six bars that have been composed but still need the figuration filling out. The end of cadenza, at the entry of the orchestra, is technically a little rough, but effective.	Studied Glinka's *Kamarinskaya*. Saw *Siegfried.* I examined how the sound of arrows being loosed is achieved in Antar (Rimski-Korsakov's Symphony No.2, Op.9). I need a similar effect in the *Scherzo*.
April 2	In the evening I pressed on with orchestrating the Concerto. Previously I had wanted to delay making a start on this until all the music, in particular the solo piano part, had been composed in detail. Now, however, with only a few short passages remaining to be written out, I decided not to wait any longer, but to start on the instrumentation, intending to complete the unfinished passages in between whiles. I started writing the score with the immense satisfaction. While going through the composition process I had already been working out in my imagination the orchestral texture I wanted, so there was no difficulty in laying out on the pages of a full score the light and transparent accompaniment I envisaged, nor the notation of the solo piano part. A very enjoyable process. In this Concerto I made two discoveries: the first is that the orchestra is given no material whatsoever to present independently, and the pianist, once having started to play, does not cease until the final bar. This is surely no bad thing; on the contrary, I feel that it creates a certain tension in the listener and fixes his attention irrevocably on the soloist. Secondly, the score turns out to be shorter (fewer pages) than I imagined, the orchestral accompaniment being of such transparency that each page can accommodate more than one line of full score.	
April 5	By nine o'clock I was already sitting down to the score of the Concerto... Returning home I sat down again to the score. Around nine I felt I had done enough and telephoned Max.	

April 7	Went on orchestrating all morning and until half past two. I am proud of the fact that the orchestral texture of the Concerto is so transparent. I had difficulties with one passage where the brass section of the orchestra drowns the soloist...but strange as it may seem, I particularly like this place.	Scriabin's *Divine Poem* is a wonderful work, even if open to criticism for its occasional *longueurs*, indecent length and orchestration that is not always impeccable (for example, the lame attempt to reproduce the billing and cooing of doves; the opening of the second movement, and the grandiose repetition of the same theme at the end of the movement, where the strings do something incomprehensible instead of exploiting their timbre to breathe life onto the brass's flaccid trumpeting of the theme.
April 9	I finished the six bars in the cadenza I had left uncompleted, and by sitting and working until three finished orchestrating the first movement.	
April 11	Did not feel like starting to orchestrate the *Scherzo*. Played through on the piano the first movement of the Concerto and was enraptured by the splendid sound of the cadenza, the first time I had been able to play it right through.	Played from memory the pieces I had been working on with Yesipova
April 15	I got a lot of the score written—eight pages, that is the whole trio of the *Scherzo*. I also thought out the reprise, which I have not yet composed.	Sergey's 22 birthday: "I feel myself to be much younger than this number; I should like to be no more that nineteen, and regret being as much as twenty-two."
April 16	In the morning and until two o'clock worked on the scoring of the *Intermezzo*, keeping it light and completing 8 pages.	Long walk with Max.
April 19	In the morning I achieved four pages of the *Intermezzo* and treated myself to a play through of the first-movement cadenza, which I much enjoyed doing. It is beginning to come together, and lies very well under fingers.	Myaskovsky, as "Misanthrope" published an article in *Muzyka* "about the Beleyev Concerts, in which he tears into the managers and the untalented composers whose works are programmed. He concludes by asking the question: why are composers like Tcherepnin and Mehrwolf and the like not being played, including 'the young, ebullient Prokofiev'..."
April 23	In the morning and until two o'clock orchestrated the *Intermezzo*. Thank God, the end is in sight, and tomorrow I should finish it. But my God, what a long piece it has turned out to be! This was not my intention at all, but I cannot cut anything out of it,	4/21: went out for some air, to show Max the designs for our suits that the tailor had brought around. I stayed with him for a while so that by the time I returned home it was already one o'clock and I did

	otherwise the form will be lost. The idea of it is that the music moves from G minor to somewhere else and arrives at the trio, while the reprise returns to G minor at the same time as most of the melodic ideas, both their general shape and their treatment, go from high to low pitch and from forte to piano, whereas at the beginning of the movement the general tendency is from low to high and from piano to forte.	not after all manage to finish the Intermezzo today, since Max and I had arranged to go for a walk at four.
April 24	Made a start on orchestrating the *Finale.* I really had not expected the orchestration to drag on for so long. After all, the reprise and the *Scherzo* are not finished yet.	I joined Max and we went to choose material for our suits. We want them to be red, the same red as Max had seen his uncle, and artist, wearing. At home I studied the scores...of the Tchaikovsky and Glazunov Concertos. The orchestration of the latter is appalling! Max and I exchanged walking sticks. I had always liked his, and he had taken a fancy to mine. The swap was his idea but I was more than ready to agree.
April 25	I did more orchestration.	...went to meet Max at the Conservatoire.. then we went to the Maly Theatre. After the show Max got hold of a car and we took the girls home, chatting away happily.
April 27	In the morning there were still a few passages in the *Finale* to finish, after which I only managed to orchestrate a couple pages. I am beginning to wonder anxiously when I shall ever finish the Concerto: the *Finale* is pretty long, and there is the two-piano version to do, and all this with the Graduation Concert coming up for which there is going to be a mass of work.	Returning home I settled down to orchestrating, but the tailor came for a fitting, and Max came as well to see that the material for my new suit looked like, so that he could order the same for himself. Max approved of the *Allemande* and the (yet unfinished) *Rigaudon*.
May 1	Max Schmidthof kills himself.	
May 4	I spent the evening looking through the scores of Tchaikovsky concerto and Shaposhinkov's ballet.	
May 6	I practiced piano, wrote my diary and composed a bit more of the *Rigaudon.*	
May 7	Sat down to *Rigaudon* and finished it.	
May 12	In the evening I worked on a 2-piano score of the Concerto.	Conducted Tchaikovsky's Piano Concerto. Two days later conducted Brahm's Violin Concerto and Saint-Saens' Piano Concerto

May 13	Spent the morning making the two-piano version of the Concerto.	
May 16	In the best of spirits. Worked on orchestrating the *Finale*.	5/18: My visit to the Meshcherskys had reawakened in me the desire to compose a *rigaudon*. The one I thought I had written was not in fact one, because it was in a slow tempo. I now set to and began to write a quick, lively piece.
May 21	...managed to work out the episode in the Finale of the Concerto where the first movement theme is repeated. This has hitherto resisted my efforts.	Finished off my jolly little *Rigaudon*.
May 27	At four o'clock I finished the Finale of the Concerto. Apart from the trio of the Scherzo, the work is complete.	

APPENDIX B

List of Recordings of the Second Piano Concerto

Year of recording	Label/year of issue or re-issue	Performers
1953	Remington Musirama (1953). APR (2011)	Jorge Bolet, piano. Thor Johnson/ Cincinnati Symphony Orchestra
1954	2008: MUSIC & ARTS	Pietro Scarpini, piano. Dimitri Mitropoulos/New York Philharmonic Symphony Orchestra
1956	HMV (1956). Medici Masters (2001)	Shura Cherkassky, piano. Herbert Menge/Philharmonia Orchestra
1959?		Vladimir Ashkenazy, piano. Kirill Kondrashin/Leningradskaya gosudarstvennaia filarmoniia.
1958	Philharmonic Society of New York (2000)	Vladimir Ashkenazy, piano. Leonard Bernstein/New York Philharmonic
1958	RCA Victor	Nicole Henriot-Schweitzer, piano. Charles Munch/Boston Symphony Orchesra
1959	Melodiya (1959, 2011); Artia (1960)	Yakov Izralevich Zak, piano. Kurt Sanderling/Vsesoiuznoe radio orchestra
1960	RCA Victor	Malcolm Frager, piano. René Leibowitz/Société des concerts du Conservatoire. Orchestre.
1961	BRILLIANT CLASSICS (2011)	Vladimir Ashkenazy, piano, Gennady Rozhdestvensky/USSR State Symphony Orchestra ("Ultimate Piano Concerto Collection")
1962	VOX; Suite 102 (2010)	Friedrich Wührer, piano. Michael Gielen/ Baden-Baden Radio Symphony Orchestra
1964	Supraphon (1964, 2002)	Dagmar Baloghová, piano. Karel Ancerl/Czech Philharmonic Orchestra
1966	RCA Victor	John Browning, piano. Erich Leinsdorf/Boston Symphony Orchestra
1969	Hall of Fame. USSR (1969) Koch, 1992	Vladimir Ashkenazy, piano. Kirill Kondrashin/Moskovskaia gosudarstvennaia filarmoniia.
1969	Berlin Classics (2006)	Peter Rösel, piano. Heinz Bongartz/Leipzig Radio Symphony Orchestra

1973	Genesis (1973, 1991)	Jorge Bolet, piano. Aislee Cox/Nuremberg Symphony Orchestra.
1974	HMV/Eterna (1974), EMI Classics (2008)	Michael Beroff, piano. Kurt Masur, conductor. Leipzig Gewandhaus Orchestra
1975	Decca (1975, 2003)	Vladimir Ashkenazy, piano. Andre Previn, conductor. London Symphony Orchestra
1976	Candide (1976), VOX BOX (1992)	Gabriel Tacchino, piano. Louis de Froment, conductor. Luxembourg Radio Orchestra.
1977	HMV/Melodiya	Dmitri Alexeyev, piano. Yuri Temirkanov, conductor. Royal Philharmonic Orchestra.
1978	DEUTSCHE GRAMMOPHON	Abdel Rahman El Bacha, piano. Georges-Élie Octors/Belgian National Orchestra
1984	Testament (2010)	Horacio Gutierrez,piano. Klaus Tennstedt, conductor. Berlin Philharmonic Orchestra
1984	Melodiya	Vladimir Krainev, piano. Dmitri Kitayenko/Moscow Philharmonic Orchestra
1985	Melodiya (1985, 1996)	Victoria Postnikova, piano. Gennady Rozhdestvensky/USSR Ministry of Culture Symphony Orchestra
1985	OPUS	Marian Lapsansky, piano. Zdenek Košler/Slovak Philharmonic Orchestra
1986	RPO/MCA	Janis Vakarelis, piano. Witold Rowicki/Royal Philharmonic Orchestra
1987	FONTEC	Andrei Diev, piano Yukinori Tezuka/Tokyo Metropolitan Symphony Orchestra
1989	CBS Masterworks	Vladimir Feltsman, piano. Michael Tilson Thomas/London Symphony Orchestra
1991	BBC LEGENDS (2002)	Shura Cherkassky, piano Kent Nagano/London Philharmonic Orchestra
1992	CHANDOS CHAN (1992, 2009)	Horacio Gutierrez, piano Neeme Järvi/Royal Concertgebouw Orchestra
1993	TELDEC (1993) APEX (2005)	Vladimir Krainev, piano Dmitri Kitayenko/Frankfurt Radio Symphony Orchestra
1994	SONY CLASSICAL (1994, 2003)	Yefim Bronfman, piano. Zubin Mehta/Israel Philharmonic Orchestra

1994	NAXOS	Kun-Woo Paik, piano Antoni Wit/Polish Radio Television Symphony Orchestra, Katowice
1996	ABC CLASSICS	Sergei Tarasov, piano Edvard Tchivzel/Sydney Symphony Orchestra
1996	HYPERION	Nikolai Demidenko, piano Alexander Lazarev/London Philharmonic Orchestra
1996	GALLO	Adilia Alieva, piano Walter Proost /San Remo Symphony Orchestra
1998	PHILIPS (1998) DECCA (2012)	Alexander Toradze, piano Valery Gergiev/St. Petersburg Mariinsky Theater Orchestra
1998	SUPRAPHON (2003)	Igor Andrasev, piano Leos Skvarovsky/Prague Symphony Orchestra
2005	FUGA LIBERA	Abdel Rahman El Bacha, piano Kazushi Ono/Symphony Orchestra of La Monnaie
2005	DANACORD	Oleg Marshev, piano Niklas Willén/South Jutland Symphony Orchestra
2007	NORTHERN FLOWERS	Eliane Rodrigues, piano Edward Serov/St. Petersburg Philharmonic Orchestra
2008	DEUTSCHE GRAMMOPHON	Yundi Li, piano Seiji Ozawa/Berlin Philharmonic Orchestra
2009	EMI CLASSICS	Evgeni Kissin, piano Vladimir Ashkenazy/Philharmonia Orchestra
2010	TRITON	Alexander Gavrylyuk, piano Vladimir Ashkenazy/Sydney Symphony Orchestra
2010	BIS	Freddy Kempf, piano Andrew Litton/Bergen Philharmonic Orchestra
2010	NAÏVE	Anna Vinnitskaya, piano Gilbert Varga/Deutsches Symphonie-Orchester Berlin
2011	ABC CLASSICS	Daniel Hill, piano Janos Fürst/Sydney Symphony Orchestra